The Long Dark

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31965334.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), catradora - Relationship

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Claustrophobia, Caves, Exploring, Post-Season/Series 05 Finale, death mentioned

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The Long Dark

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Catra has been interested in Half Moon off and on ever since the end of the war. Now, freshly married and in their new home, Adora comes home one day with a little bit of news that refreshes her interest. Could it be possible that they could find the lost civilization of Half Moon?

Notes

Normally I just say “Shall we?” here. However, I kind of feel like I should say this though: Don’t explore caves by yourself if you have no experience at it. It’s dangerous without the proper training and help, not to mention you could damage the fragile cave environment and hurt the animals within. But if you do want to try it out there's ways of doing so. Contact a local spelunking club and they'll be happy to help you out. It's a cool experience. The best description I've heard for caving, especially new ones, is Neil Armstrong stuff. You're going places no one has ever gone before. If you're in the United States of America, you can find clubs at the National Speleological Society (https://caves.org/).

Decisions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Then they all got really bored after that because I swear, the rest was the First Ones' version of a grocery list," Adora said as she sat down at the table in their kitchen. "Interesting but not real fun to hear recited."

She took a deep breath of the air, still scented with the fresh cut and varnished wood of the cabinets. Catra finished slicing up an apple and slid the pieces onto a plate with some cheese and crackers and sat in front of Adora as she sat down next to her. They hadn't been in the house more than a few months but they'd already settled down in it like it was fit to them.

"What was that part you were saying about a cave?" Catra said as she speared a piece of cheese on a claw and started nibbling at it.

"Oh, that. It was them talking about some cave down in Plumeria. It's close to the rainforest," Adora replied.

Catra chewed for a moment, thinking, before she said, "Could you tell me exactly what it said?"

Adora shrugged as she carefully lined up a piece of cheese, a cracker, and then carefully laid a slice of apple on top of it all.

"Not exactly. Why?"

Catra felt stupid bringing it up and had to quiet the voice in her head as she said, "Because remember that fascination I had with Half Moon? The last place they were seen was Plumeria and there's rumors they retreated into a cave."

"You think it's this cave?" Adora said. "I mean, there's got to be a bunch of caves around."

Catra settled down in her chair a little as she said, "I mean, maybe? Did it have any kind of location beyond just that?"

Adora nodded as she chewed on her carefully constructed snack. When she was done she said, "It had a map. I can get a picture of it if you want."

"Yeah, that'd be good," Catra said.

"Picking up the old interest again?" Adora said with a smile as she started stacking up more crackers, cheese, and apple again.

“Adora, I’m not even thirty yet. I don’t think I can say an interest is old yet,” Catra said.

“Well you haven’t mentioned it in a while,” Adora said.

“Yeah, because we both had the wedding and the house to do,” Catra said. “You had that survey of the Waste and I had the art show. We’ve been a bit busy.”

“Just saying,” Adora said as Catra reached out and snagged her cracker stack. “Hey!”

“Stolen food tastes better,” Catra said between chewing.

“OK, but I want this next one so wait to steal another,” Adora said, shaking her head as she started again.

“But if you know which one I’m going to grab, it’s not stolen,” Catra said with a grin. Adora gave her a little playful push and Catra dodged it and then leaned into her shoulder, purring.

“Ah, the old purr ploy,” Adora said as she took a slice of apple and held it in front of Catra’s mouth. Catra opened her mouth and Adora set it in. “You’re impossible.”

“You married me though so it must not be that impossible,” Catra said. Adora kissed the top of her head then and the two spent some time talking and eating before they went on their way for the afternoon.

Catra went into her studio and started rummaging around in a few of the boxes that still hadn’t been unpacked from when they moved. She finally found an accordion folder marked as “Research.” She flipped through until she found the Half Moon section and pulled out the stuff she had on it. She and Adora had spent time after the war catching up on things they didn’t know about and she remembered the first time she’d seen a story about a race of cat people retreating into a secret place. She still didn’t know anything about who her parents had been or where she’d come from and while she hadn’t really ever been obsessed with it, it was something that tickled at her, a little unknown she wanted to know about. To see that there may have been a whole kingdom of cat people was something she had decided she needed to find out about.

Of course, that’s when she found out just how much of a myth Half Moon had been. She’d seen everything from where it was claimed it was a sunken kingdom under the ocean, that they’d retreated when the Horde had first formed even though everything else seemed to indicate they hadn’t been seen in centuries, that they’d left the planet even though they’d been in Despondos at the time, and then Catra’s favorite which was that they simply had just disappeared into thin air. She liked to think they’d gotten annoyed and just said, “Done!” before evaporating. What she had been able to piece together was that the most definite last sighting was in Plumeria and that most of the legends mentioned a cave.

She rummaged through the papers until she found a hand drawn map she'd made of Plumeria that showed a few locations she'd figure out of sightings. They were near where former towns and villages in Plumeria had been. She'd had a hard time figuring that one out because Plumeria really didn't have anything that could be considered long term habitation, the people being fairly into moveable structures as well as temporary constructions except for a few exceptions on the far north end of the kingdom, and she'd finally figured it out when Perfuma had said that her people used to live in more permanent structures but had stopped doing so some time back. As she sat the map down, Adora came into the room and set a large printed photo on her drafting table next to her it.

Catra took a look at the photo and saw the abstracted images that the First Ones left behind and said, "Adora, I love you but that doesn't make a lot of sense to me."

"The blocks of color are regions," Adora said, pointing at them. "This one is the rainforest area in southern Plumeria, this one is around where the Heart-Blossom is, and this one is the area that it's said the cave is in."

Catra looked at her map and then at the one Adora had set down and then back again a few times.

"This tracks," Catra said, pointing at both with pinky and thumb. "The last area that they were seen in was around here and this is saying the cave is somewhere in here too. What with all the legends mentioning caves, I wouldn't be surprised if this is it."

“I checked the region. It’s got a lot of limestone under it and maps show a lot of rivers and streams,” Adora said. “My books say that’s prime cave country.”

Catra sat back as she looked at it and said, “Could be another cave too. Could be that it just never happened. Do you have a precise location on it?”

Adora leaned against the table looking at both pieces of paper as she said, “Yes, but it’s in a First Ones’ coordinate system. We’re still trying to figure that out.”

Catra tapped her fingers along the table top before she said, “I feel like you’re holding back something.”

Adora scratched the back of her head as she said, “Well… I think I’ve figured out some of it but I’m not sure. I needed to get with the Etherian Surveying Society working group I’ve been talking with about it to double check it anyway.”

“Uh, Adora, we can double check it by running it through whatever you’ve got and then going to where it says it is,” Catra said. “If there’s a cave there, then you’re probably right.”

“That’s true,” Adora said. “You’re going to want to go in aren’t you?”

“Well, yeah!” Catra said with a grin.

“Have you ever explored a cave before?” Adora replied.

“Have you?” Catra said. “That crystal cave on an entirely different planet doesn’t count.”

“No, but I’m sure we can figure it out,” Adora said.

“You’re going to go read a book aren’t you?” Catra replied, her ears twitching in amusement.

“No, I’m going to read *several* books,” Adora laughed. “And so are you.”

“I should probably check out if we can borrow a skiff from someone,” Catra said. “You got enough tents and stuff we shouldn’t need to borrow any of that.”

“Did we just decide on some expedition?” Adora said.

Catra grinned as she said, “It’s not like we had anything else pressing on us.”

“True. OK, you look up the skiff, I’ll get some books to see how hard this could be and then we’ll go from there,” Adora said.

A few days later, Adora was sitting at the kitchen table, making notes from the book she was reading, when she heard a humming noise that turned into the roar of a skiff coming in for a landing in the backyard. She slid the door open to see Catra shutting it down and grinning at her.

“Where in the world did you find that!?” Adora said, gesturing at the scuffed Horde green paint on it.

“Know that guy who runs the surplus store on the outskirts of Bright Moon?” Catra responded as she sat down on the edge of it.

“Clem? Yeah, what about him?” Adora said.

“Turns out he doesn’t pay close attention to the keys for his surplus skiffs,” Catra said.

Adora stood there for a moment as the comment sunk in before she shouted out, “ *You stole a skiff* !?”

“What? Like you haven’t?” Catra said, her tail flicking back and forth.

"That was from the Horde! This is completely different! Catra! Take it back!"

"Calm down, I'm just messing with you," Catra said. “I borrowed it from Clem. He said not a lot of people want them since that one place started turning out newer versions and he’s got a whole line of them sitting out back of his place. He said I could borrow it.”

“OK, well, I have fun news for you then. You know your deep love of water?” Adora said with a grin.

“I don’t like where this is going,” Catra said, her tail going still and her ears flattening out a little.

“Turns out caves have a lot of it,” Adora said as she walked over to the skiff. “And you have to go through it, a lot sometimes.”

Catra thought about it for a long moment and then said, “OK. No big deal.”

Adora leaned against the skiff as she said in a sing-song voice, “Your ears say different.”

“You leave my ears out of this. We’re still going. I took the time to get this thing started and going, we’re at least going to go,” Catra

said. “Any luck on getting the coordinate system figured out?”

“Yep. I fed it through the data pad this morning. Got a location too that at least puts it in the same region as what the old map says,” Adora said.

Catra looked at the back of the house for a moment before she said, “When do you think we should leave?”

“I’ve got enough stuff in the attic for us,” Adora said. “We probably need to get familiar with our old mountain training. Sounds like we might have to do a lot of rope work from what I’m reading.”

“OK, see, that’s better news than water. You should have led with that,” Catra said.

“You should have led with that you didn’t steal a skiff but here we are,” Adora responded.

“Should we maybe bring some people with us?” Catra said.

“Who do you think?” Adora said.

Catra started to name a few names but stopped as she got a thoughtful look on her face.

"Pretty much everyone I can think of is busy."

"Yeah, I was just thinking the same thing," Adora replied. "The books do say not to go with less than four people but…"

"You're about to mention She-Ra aren't you?" Catra said.

"Well, yeah," Adora said. "I mean, that's three right there. I think we'd be able to manage."

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose while she said, "Adora, aren't you the one who said to Perfuma the other day you don't want to rely on her and you wanted to build your own reputation?"

"Well, yeah, but it'll just be us," Adora said.

"Let me at least reach out to Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie," Catra said. "They have all the mountain training too and they might be free."

"OK, give it a try," Adora said. "I'll get the stuff out of the attic."

A few hours later, Catra walked into the living room to find Adora surrounded by equipment. She was unfolding a huge tent across the couch, the purple colors of Bright Moon on the canvas making it seem festive.

"Adora, are you seriously considering taking that? Aren't we going to be in a cave? I don't think we'll have to worry about rain," Catra said as she perched herself on the edge of the couch.

"I figure we might need it before or after," Adora said. "Could you check the rope? It's in those bags over there."

Catra picked up one of the bags Adora had nodded at and started taking it out, checking the outer woven sheath to be sure it wasn't damaged while also running her hand along it checking for weak spots on the inner core.

"Alright, I talked with Kyle. He said that Lonnie's busy for the foreseeable future helping out the Hordies but he and Rogelio can come along if we want," Catra said. "I told him we'd probably leave this weekend and be gone for a week. Whatta you think?"

Adora looked up from inspecting the seams of the tent and said, "Yeah, that should work. There's some cliffs by where this says it should be. If we find a cave, we can get familiar with the climbing stuff again before we have to go in. Do you think we should wait for Melog to come back?"

Catra shook her head as she worked.

"Naw, they said they might be gone for a while. They're really loving running around Etheria. I'll leave them a note though, let them know where we went. The rest sounds good. Food?"

"We'll have to get some dried stuff. Pack a few self-heating things too but we can't really cook. Carbon monoxide danger from stoves," Adora said and then stopped. "Actually, that's a big question. How far do we go into this cave before we decide we're done?"

"Well, just until we see it all right?" Catra said. "Do we really need to worry about cooking?"

"I mean, yeah. There's a cave near Salineas I read about that's miles and miles long. We could be in there for a day or more."

"That makes sense. If they hid in this cave, that means it's big," Catra said. "Let's plan for a couple days at least."

"That makes the most sense to me. I say four days total. Two in, two back out," Adora said.

Catra stopped and thought about that before she replied.

“That’s a long time underground,” Catra said. “You sure?”

“Better safe than sorry,” Adora said.

“OK, yeah, let's do that then,” Catra said. “I think Clem has some old Horde rations we could bring.”

Adora looked long and hard at Catra as Catra continued to check the rope with a straight face.

“You had better be kidding,” Adora finally said.

“What? Clem has a lot of stuff like that,” Catra said, her face as innocent as she could manage before she finally started laughing. “No, we’re not bringing that.”

“Good. I’d have to reconsider this relationship if you did,” Adora said, laughing.

Catra tossed a pillow at her as she replied, “Sorry, you’re stuck with me.”

Adora caught the pillow with a smile.

“Good.”

Chapter End Notes

I was originally going to do this as a single chapter story but when I realized I was 7,000 words in, I decided to go ahead and start posting in chapters. Hope you enjoy it!

Base Camp

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra get ready to leave and go to the where they think the cave entrances is located.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Several days later, they'd finalized the plan, got the skiff loaded and were puttering around the house in the early morning hours when Adora's data pad buzzed.

"Hey, Kyle," Adora said as she answered it. "Still meeting us by the Heart-Blossom?"

"Uh… no? That's kind of why I'm calling. I… we can't come," Kyle said, scratching at his chin.

"What's wrong? Do you need us to come pick you up?" Catra said as she stuck her head over Adora's shoulder.

"No, it's not that. Rogelio's sick, so's Lonnie, and I'm having to take care of both of them," Kyle said. "It started last night. I'm so sorry, guys."

“Don’t worry about it,” Adora said. “It happens. You need our help?”

Kyle shook his head as they both heard Lonnie off screen get violently ill. “No, I can handle this. Thanks for understanding.”

“It’s alright,” Catra said. “Take care of them!”

Kyle said goodbye and then hung up as Catra sat back against the counter.

“Well, dang it. Now what?”

“We can still go. See what’s there,” Adora said.

“True. OK, let’s go ahead and do that,” Catra said. “You left the message with Sparkles to let her know we’d be gone and how long?”

“Yep. Sent it this morning,” Adora said. “Told her we’d check in if we found anything.”

“OK, well, let’s go see what’s out there then,” Catra said.

They got up on the skiff and after a short playful argument of who would fly, Adora took them up and got them headed towards Plumeria. As they flew, Adora noticed some of the gauges didn't seem to work quite right.

"Is this thing safe?" Adora said to Catra, lounging in front of her.

"Yeah, checked it over myself," Catra said.

"Some of the gauges just seem like they're not working," Adora said as she watched one indicator go up and down in a slow curve.

"Yeah, the gauges are a little wonky but just listen to the engine. You'll be alright," Catra said.

"I can see it now. 'Catra and Adora, heroes of Etheria, survivors of multiple battles, lost in junk skiff accident.' Sounds real great doesn't it?" Adora said.

"Hey, don't speak about Skiffy like that! They're reliable," Catra said.

Adora snorted as she said, "Skiffy?"

Catra gave her a look and Adora just laughed.

"Alright, well, Skiffy, keep us in the air please," Adora said while she patted the controls.

Later, halfway through the day, they were followed by a flock of large winged birds as they started to fly over Plumeria.

"How are those things keeping up?" Catra said, watching them pace the skiff.

"I have no idea. It doesn't look like they're flapping hard or anything, does it?" Adora said.

"They're not dangerous are they?" Catra said.

"I don't think so. Never seen them before to be honest," Adora said. "Get a few pictures. Perfuma will probably want to see them."

Catra snapped a few shots and after a while, the birds fell away from them towards the forest. As the evening came on, Adora started to fly along a river, colorful trees flashing along beneath them.

“OK, we’re almost there,” Adora said. “Should be a little further along.”

Catra looked around at the steep hills covered by trees and the little streams flowing down them and to the main river and said, “Pretty country at least.”

“You think your ancestors lived around here?” Adora said.

“No. They lived closer to the Crimson Waste. This is where history, well, legend, says they had to run to,” Catra said. “Something about people attacking them. They got pushed out of a few places I guess.”

Adora was silent as she came around a curve in the river and spied the waterfall she’d been looking for.

“It’s right around here,” Adora said. “Or should be if I’m right on those coordinates.”

Catra looked around as she said, “Fly around a little. Let’s see if we can spot anything from up here.”

Adora nodded and started flying in an expanding square out from a small field at the base of the cliff that the waterfall fell down. They both looked but after an hour of flying they didn’t see

anything. Adora finally brought them in for a landing in the small field.

"I'm not sure what I was expecting to see," Catra said. "I mean, if it's here, it's probably hidden. It's not like they're going to put out a huge sign."

Adora sat down next to her on the skiff as she said, "Well, we can't do it tonight but we'll start searching tomorrow. I'll set up a search grid on my data pad. We'll be methodical about it."

"Where does the coordinates show that the cave was?" Catra said.

Adora pointed at the other side of the waterfall and said, "Right there."

"Just so you know, when it comes time to search that area, we are flying over," Catra said.

Adora laughed and agreed as they both got up and started unpacking. As the area darkened, they both sat with their backs against the skiff as they watched the waterfall.

"What's your thinking on our chances of finding something?" Catra said.

“I don't know to be honest. I mean, this is kind of a long shot chance we're looking at here," Adora said. "Gotta assume I did my calculations right, that your details are right, that it's not just some baseless legend… I'd say not a big chance.”

“True. You know, even if we find nothing, this is kind of nice,” Catra said right before a screech split the evening air. “OK, that isn’t. What is that?”

Catra jumped up onto the skiff as Adora reached into an open hatch and tossed her up a handheld spotlight. They heard the screech again as Catra turned on the spotlight and lit up a tree at the edge of the clearing. A large furry creature, about the size of a large dog, sat perched on a branch as it held still in the sudden bright light. Catra couldn’t help but notice the claws holding it in place on all four of its paws as well as its large eyes that had already squinted down from the light. It looked a bit longer before dropping to the ground and running away, low to the ground.

“OK, we’re alright,” Adora said. “Long as we don’t go into the bushes without looking up first.”

Catra turned off the spotlight and dropped it back to Adora.

“You know what that is?”

“I’ve seen a picture. It’s called a Howler Owl. It makes that noise to try and scare animals so they’ll either run under it or run up the tree and to it,” Adora said. “They’ll attack people but it’s rare. You just got to pay attention that you’re not going under one.”

Catra sat down as she said, “You deal with that on your surveys!?”

“That’s nothing,” Adora said with a grin. “You should have seen some of the stuff we ran into out in the Crimson Waste.”

“Nope. Don’t want to know,” Catra said as she jumped down next to Adora and hugged her. “You don’t take stupid risks do you?”

“No!” Adora said as she bumped her forehead against Catra’s. Catra looked at her with an unbelieving look.

“I have a feeling you do but you don’t know because you're just like that.”

“Well, you’re more than welcome to come along on my next survey if you’d like,” Adora said with a grin.

“That’d be nice… wait, I know that grin. What is it?” Catra said.

“Bathymetric survey of part of the Northern Reach,” Adora said, her grin getting bigger.

Catra started shaking her head, “Nope, nope, nope. You have fun with that.”

“Oh, come on! It’s during the warm part of the year! The water is mostly ice free!” Adora said. “You only need three or four layers of clothing. It should be fun!”

“Obviously you did hit your head too hard during the war,” Catra said with a laugh.

They settled into their tent for the night, getting comfy on their cots. They both tossed and turned, not able to really get to sleep until Adora finally set up and pulled her cot over until it was right against Catra’s cot. She got back into hers and their hands found each other across the divide and they both settled down a little and were soon fast asleep.

The next morning found them aloft on the skiff and looking over the landscape. Adora did the flying again and Catra looked over the side as they went, looking carefully. About halfway through the morning, they’d done a back and forth search pattern on the side of the falls that Adora’s coordinate translation indicated the entrance should be. She brought it in for a landing in a field about a mile away as Catra jumped out into the tall grass and stretched.

“Whatta think?” Adora said as she watched Catra roll her head back and forth.

“A lot of things. Maybe the coordinates are wrong, maybe the First Ones just didn’t know what they were talking about, or maybe a rock slide fell over it in the last few hundred years. You saw the base of the cliff, there’s rubble there. It’s not like it’s not a possibility,” Catra said.

“Maybe I did the coordinates wrong,” Adora said. “I mean, it could be in this area but that doesn’t mean I’m right on it.”

“How far off though?” Catra said. Adora shrugged as Catra said, “Well, we’re not going to just pack up and go. We got a ton of stuff with us. Let’s give it another try.”

“Let’s go back to camp then. I want to check a few things on the math I did,” Adora said.

“Sounds good,” Catra said as she jumped on board.

As they flew back to camp, Catra was leaning over the side, watching the river that turned into the waterfall and had to admit to herself that from high up, it was pretty. Then, as Adora banked to bring them in, Catra caught a glimpse of something halfway up the cliff but on the opposite side from where they had been looking.

“Adora! Bring us in about halfway up the right side cliff there!” Catra said, pointing to where she meant. Adora turned the controls and brought it past. They both looked as they went past and nestled back under an overhang that was almost invisible, they could just see a little opening.

“You think it’s something?” Adora said as she flew past again.

“I don’t know. Could just be a little alcove in the rocks. There’s a pile of rocks in front of it so it’s kind of hard to make out but it doesn’t look like a bad climb to get to,” Catra said as she felt herself getting excited. “Land! Let’s check it out!”

Almost as soon as they hit the ground, Catra was jumping off and started jogging towards the cliff face.

“Whoa! Hang on! Let’s get some stuff together first!” Adora said. Catra stopped and looked at her, her tail lashing back and forth in excitement before finally coming back.

“OK, but come on!” Catra said. They spent a little bit of time rummaging around and getting two daypacks as Adora handed Catra some knee and elbow pads.

“What am I supposed to do with these?” Catra said as Adora put on another set.

“Book says it’s a good idea. There could be lots of crawling if we have to go in,” Adora said before strapping a helmet to her bag and setting Catra’s helmet next to her pack.

“Adora, I didn’t get this armored up for a battle,” Catra said with a laugh.

“And maybe that’s a reason you got scars all under your fur,” Adora said. “Let’s not add anymore, OK?”

Catra started pulling the pads on as she said, “Alright, alright, but you know we’re just going up the cliff right?”

“And if there’s something there, you’re going to want to go in,” Adora said with a laugh. “I’m not climbing back down for this stuff.”

They finally got settled and went over to the cliff. It wasn’t a sheer face, more a pile of broken rock at the bottom and a steeply sloping face.

“Rope up?” Catra said.

Adora looked at the cliff and replied, “Naw. It’s not a horrible slope. Just try not to slip.”

Catra started to clamber over the rocks as she said, “I’ll just bounce with all this padding you got on me.”

Adora shook her head with a smile and followed Catra. It was less a climb and more a very steep scramble but they both got halfway up the cliff pretty quickly to what appeared to be a ledge holding more broken rock. Catra was the first to the top and Adora could hear her sudden intake of breath when she did. She looked up to see Catra looking back at her with a huge grin.

“It looks like a cave.”

A few minutes later and they both were looking into the alcove they’d spotted from the air. It was well blocked from view below by the jumble of rocks but they could plainly see the entrance not much taller than themselves but about ten feet wide with a dirt floor covered in broken stone.

“How far back you think it goes?” Adora said.

“If it’s really Half Moon… a long, long way,” Catra replied and then took a deep breath. “OK, what’s the plan?”

“I’ve got water and snacks with us so we can be in there for a little bit but we can’t stay all day or anything,” Adora said. “We’ve got the headlamps on the helmets, two back up lights in the

packs, and a handful of emergency chemical lights. I say we go in until we hit something really tight, that requires something like rope or until it’s about mid-afternoon.”

“Sounds good,” Catra said as Adora rummaged in her pack and pulled out a miniature data pad and took a few pictures.

“Smile,” Adora said as she moved to stand next to Catra and took a shot of them both. Then she typed a message out and then put the data pad back in her pack. “OK, I shot a message out that we’re going into a cave.”

“We’re just standing here though!” Catra said.

“Well then lead on,” Adora said with a little hand gesture.

Chapter End Notes

> Fun fact: the cave entrance in this is modeled after a cave entrance in the area where I live. However, it's in the middle of a very popular tourist destination so it is not the least bit secret. It's also pretty visible from almost all sides.

Into the Unknown

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora enter the cave.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The two got their helmets on and Catra grinned as she walked into the entry. They could feel a slight breeze at their back as they went in and started up the slope. About thirty feet in they reached the top of the slope and saw it continue down and to the left.

"I don't know what we found but we found something," Catra said as they started down, stepping carefully on the broken stones all over the floor as the light faded from the outside to be replaced by the glow from their headlamps. Adora didn't respond as she looked around. After only a few minutes, they both noticed walls starting to get further away and the ceiling was lowering enough they were beginning to stoop a little.

Then they both stopped because they realized they were looking at a wide crack that appeared to open up. They both looked at each other, their grins huge, before they both went forward and found themselves standing in a large room. They were standing at the top of a pile of broken stone and they both could see the room sloping downwards. Stalactites hung in long curtains from the ceiling in hues of red, orange, and cream. As their headlamps played over them, they both marveled at the play of light over the rock. They both started walking carefully forward, looking at the

formations. Adora got her miniature data pad out and took a few more pictures.

"How long do you think it's been since someone's been in here?" Catra said, her voice quiet.

Adora gave a small shrug as she said, "No one's lived around here for a long time. Could have been as far back as the First Ones."

Catra seemed to have a little shiver run up her spine for a moment before she said, "We're seeing stuff hardly anyone has ever seen before."

"If this isn't Half Moon, if we go deep enough we'll see stuff no one has ever seen before," Adora said quietly. Catra looked over at her with a look of excitement and wonder on her face.

"I'll be a bit disappointed if this isn't Half Moon but that will definitely make up for it," Catra said.

They went forward further before they saw a smaller opening at the back of the large room. It was only about four feet high and about five feet wide.

"OK, is that your definition of too tight?" Catra said, looking at Adora.

“Naw, I don’t think that looks bad. You want to go first or should I?” Adora responded.

“You. I can fit into tighter spaces. I don’t want you to get stuck trying to follow me.”

Adora nodded and got down to look into the tunnel. The walls were rippled all around and little bits of damp earth sat in the ripples on the floor as Adora started to crawl forward. The tunnel itself seemed to keep going downwards and made a sharp turn not too far inwards. She looked back at Catra and said, “I’m going to go and you come in after I’ve gone about a body length or so in. Stay that far apart so we both have room to maneuver.”

“Sounds good,” Catra responded.

Adora started crawling forward and immediately had to shift her pack a little to keep it from bumping against the ceiling with every moment. When she got to the sharp turn, she looked around the corner to see the tunnel go sharply down and then take a turn about eight feet further down.

“What’s it doing?” Catra said from behind her.

“Goes down and then takes a sharp turn,” Adora said as she thought of the shape in her head.

“Do we need to get the ropes?” Catra said.

“No, it’s not that sharp a turn. I’m going to go forward,” Adora said and then started to move. That’s when she realized the tunnel was narrowing a little. She managed to get to the bottom and the turn went into a tighter tunnel. She saw Catra’s light coming down the tunnel and managed to look over her shoulder. She saw her at the top of what she thought of as The Slide.

“It gets tighter but it looks like it keeps going,” Adora said. “You doing alright?”

“I’m good but you look like you’re re-considering this whole thing,” Catra said with a laugh.

“You know I love you if I’ll crawl into an unexplored tunnel for you,” Adora said and blew Catra a cramped kiss.

Adora took a moment and worked the quick release catches on her pack and wiggled around to get it off and stuck it in front of her to push it along. She began moving forward again, taking deep breaths to keep calm. After she’d moved forward a little, she saw the light from Catra’s lamp behind her and felt a little better knowing she’d come down The Slide behind her. The tunnel went up and down a little, mostly trending down, and after a few hundred feet they came out into a small room barely big enough to sit up in but wide enough to lay down without touching the walls. A small white flowstone formation flowed from the ceiling to

the floor in one corner and when they played their lights over it they could see it was vaguely tinted blue.

"Must have some copper in the water," Catra said and Adora gave her a look. "What? I read a few of those books too. Besides, that reminds me of a mineral paint I use sometimes. It's a similar color."

Adora pulled her miniature data pad out and tapped a few things out before taking a few pictures.

"OK, so do you want to keep going?" Adora said, nodding at where it narrowed down again.

"I should ask you the same thing," Catra said.

Adora grinned as she said, "I'm doing alright. Didn't realize I had a bit of claustrophobia. Coming down The Slide back there and seeing it narrow down? That was a moment, I'm here to tell you."

"It's not so bad for me but like I said, I can handle tight spaces better than you," Catra said. "Do you want me to lead?"

"Naw, I think you're right; it's better if I do. If I get stuck, I want that knowledge you have a bit more maneuver room," Adora said.

“Well don’t get stuck, goof,” Catra said as she nudged Adora with her shoulder. “I can’t move that much better than you. I do have to say, the pads were a good idea. That floor is not kind.”

“The book was pretty adamant on it,” Adora said as she took a sip of water from one of her bottles. “OK, let’s take the next tunnel. We still have plenty of time before we have to turn back.”

“That’s a plan. Lead on,” Catra said with a gesture.

Adora went over to the next tunnel opening and began crawling again. This one had several tight squeezes on top of several sharp curves that required contortions to get around. Time seemed to hold still for the two as they made their way down the tunnel, the only noise that seemed to be heard was the occasional drip of water and their own breath. Adora stopped finally at a tight squeeze but she could feel a breeze going past her face and she thought she could see a bigger room beyond the squeeze.

“There’s a tight squeeze here but I think there’s a bigger room past it,” Adora said.

“Thank Mara,” Catra said. “I was beginning to get scared this was going to get too tiny and we’d have to do all of that freaking backwards. Hopefully it’s at least big enough to sit like the last place.”

Adora couldn’t really tell but she thought it might be and said, “I think it is. Go on?”

“Go on,” Catra said.

Adora shoved her pack through it and then put her arms forward like she was going to dive through the opening. She began to carefully move forward, moving her shoulders to get them through, and as she did, she felt the stone pressing in on all sides of her. She stopped for a second to get her fear under control and then took a deep breath, held it, and let it all out as she pushed forward with her feet and got her top half out into the room. She pulled herself the rest of the way out and turned around to see Catra looking up the tunnel at her.

“That is not fun,” Adora said.

“Is there room to sit up in there?” Catra said as she started forward.

Adora hadn’t really noticed the room but turned around and suddenly realized that her headlamp wasn’t hitting the back of the room or the sides. She looked up and saw huge stalactites hanging from the ceiling as well as stalagmites on the floor. She could just make out the ceiling in her headlamp light. After a moment of awe, she looked back and said, “Yeah, a little.”

“Well, try and move out of my way; I’m coming through,” Catra said.

Adora stepped back and watched as Catra came through without much struggle. She waited for Catra to get out and then watched her face as she noticed the size of the room.

“Wow!” Catra said, looking around. “How big is this!?”

“I have no idea,” Adora said as she took a few pictures. “Big.”

“Do we have time to explore it?” Catra said.

“Plenty. Let’s see what’s what,” Adora said as she picked up her pack and the two started walking. After a little bit, Catra spoke up.

“This has to be at least twice as big as that first room. The ceiling is what? Sixty feet up?”

“Probably closer to a hundred,” Adora said, looking up. As they went silent, they both heard the rushing noise of water.

“Is that a… river?” Catra said.

“It’s something flowing,” Adora said.

“Where is it?”

“I can’t tell. Let’s try over this way,” Adora said, pointing further into the room. After a few more minutes, they came to the edge of a huge crack in the ground, dropping straight down. They could see what looked like a small waterfall coming out of the opposite wall of the drop about thirty feet lower than they were.

“Did you see any other exits out of here?” Adora said.

Catra looked around some more and shook her head. “No. That doesn’t mean there isn’t one. The one we came in was pretty small.”

“Then if we can’t find another way to go, I’d say we’ve hit that spot we talked about and this is as far as we go today. We need ropes to get down this,” Adora said with a nod towards the drop.

“How deep is that?” Catra said, carefully looking over the side.

Adora held her miniature data pad over the drop and then looked at it.

“Data pad says sixty seven meters, so about 220 feet,” Adora said.

“Ok, yeah, ropes,” Catra said.

Adora laughed as she said, “Were you going to just jump and hope if it wasn’t too far?”

“No! I was just curious,” Catra replied.

“Well don’t get too curious, that’s a long drop,” Adora said. “We’ve still got time. Let’s explore the room some more and then head back.”

They explored the room some more, found another hole that ended up only going back a few feet before narrowing down to little more than a crack a few paper widths wide, and finally made their way back towards where they’d entered the room. As they went, Catra said, “You know, this is really cool but we haven’t seen anything that shows anyone has ever been in here.”

Adora was standing beside a massive single stone formation, creamy white and red, that was twice as tall as she was and watched as a drop fell from the ceiling to the top of it and then slowly slid down the stone.

“I know what you mean. Do you not want to bother anymore?” Adora said.

“Of course I want to keep going,” Catra said. “This is still pretty cool like I said.”

Adora nodded as she walked around to the back of the stone formation where it came close to the wall. She was looking at the base when her headlamp caught some weird shape in the mud behind it. She got closer and knelt down to take a look. In the light of her headlamp, she saw a single paw print. She felt like time stopped.

“What’s going on?” Catra said. “Whatcha looking at?”

“Catra, you haven’t walked over here have you?” Adora said as she looked back at Catra.

“No. Why?”

Adora looked back down again and realized that it couldn’t be Catra. Catra was wearing boots. She stared at the paw print for a moment longer before she looked back at Catra.

“I think we’re onto something. There’s a paw print in the mud here,” Adora said.

Catra stared at her, her eyes wide, before suddenly scrambling over to her.

“Where!?”

Adora pointed and Catra stared at it over Adora’s shoulder as Adora got out her data pad and took two pictures of it, one by itself and one with her hand held next to it for scale.

“It… it doesn’t mean anything. Could be anything,” Catra said but Adora could hear the excitement in her voice.

“Yeah, anything,” Adora said.

Catra looked back at her with wide eyes.

“Let’s go get those ropes.”

Chapter End Notes

> That one room with the little flowstone in it is taken directly from a cave room I went into when I was a kid at summer camp. I have a very vivid memory of it because I want to say that's when I first figured out that I was a bit claustrophobic. It was pretty neat but would have been even more so if we hadn't heard someone shouting down the tunnels for us and when we got out they asked my counselor what he was

thinking because didn't he know there was a storm coming and he knew the cave flooded when it rained.

The Drop

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora prepare to rappel inside the cave and push further on.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The journey back out took them longer. They were going uphill after all and when they got back to the room right before The Slide, they both took a moment to lay out and relax and break into the snacks.

"I cannot believe how hungry I am right now," Adora said as she crammed a handful of peanuts, chocolate, and dried fruit into her mouth.

"That's not just walking around we're doing," Catra said around a mouthful.

"I know, but still," Adora said and then looked at the tunnel. "I just realized getting up The Slide is going to be interesting."

Catra nodded as she said, "That's no joke. That thing is just long enough you can't just grab the top and pull yourself up. Want me to try?"

“Yeah, I’ll let you go first on that one,” Adora said.

“I was going to tease you about that and then I realized you went through that squeeze first before the big room not knowing just what was on the other side,” Catra said. “Can’t really give you grief over this.”

They both moved over to the last stretch of narrow tunnel as Adora said, “I gotta say, as much fun as this has been, that part was not part of the fun.”

“Well, just imagine trying to push through it with all the gear we’re going to be hauling when we come back through,” Catra said with a grin before she shimmied up the tunnel.

“Thanks, I was trying not to think about that,” Adora said as she watched Catra’s feet and twitching tail go into the tunnel.

Not long after they walked down the slope to the entrance, afternoon light filtering in, and they both marveled at how wide the entrance seemed compared to when they’d first come in as well as the strong smell of vegetation compared to the relatively sterile air of the cave. They sat on the edge of the rock jumble in silence for a moment as they both unstrapped their helmets and turned the headlamps off to take in the quiet rumble of the waterfall and the sounds of wind through the trees.

They finally made their way down the rock face and back over to their campsite. They both kicked off their boots with a sigh while Catra got a brush out and started brushing through the mud stuck in her fur as Adora sent a message out to let people know that they'd got back out of the cave and hooked her miniature data pad up to her full size one.

"I'm going to have to take a bath when this is all over, I just know it," Catra said.

"I think we need to go to Mystacor after we've finished this up," Adora said. "We haven't seen Casta in forever and I have a feeling we're going to want to hit up the massages and hot springs."

"Massage, yes, hot spring, that's all you," Catra said.

"Ah, you don't want to even dip your feet in with me?" Adora said with mock hurt on her face.

"You're lucky I go in that room," Catra responded.

Adora grinned and then gave a sigh as she stood up. She got in their tent to go through the gear and to get some clean clothes. As she changed she said, "I'm going to start dinner. You got any preferences?"

“Naw, whatever we brought is fine,” Catra said. “When I’m done with this you care if I take a nap?”

“You know I never refuse to see you napping,” Adora said with a grin as she started to set up the stove they’d brought on a folding table.

As evening came on, Adora woke up Catra and the two sat down at the folding table. Right as they were about to eat, they saw Glimmer teleport into the field near them. She spotted them both and teleported to stand right by the table.

“What did you find!?” Glimmer said before they could say anything.

“Hello, Glimmer, good to see you, how have you been? How’s Bow?” Catra said with mocking patience.

“Yes, hello; Bow’s still at that thing with his dads, I’ve made the pleasantries, now what did you find!?” Glimmer said.

“What makes you think we found anything?” Adora said, mimicking Catra’s tone before she took a bite.

“That’s what I’m asking!” Glimmer said.

“Sit down, Sparkles. Grab a bowl, Adora cooks like she’s cooking for her whole survey crew,” Catra said.

“I did not,” Adora said. Catra eyeballed the pot full of food, looked at her brimming bowl, and declined to say anything. Glimmer grumbled but grabbed a bowl and sat down with them.

“OK, I’ve got a bowl, I’m eating, tell me what’s going on,” Glimmer said. Catra and Adora took turns filling her in and when it came time to tell her about the paw print, they both stopped.

“Go ahead, this is your project,” Adora said with a gesture at Catra.

“We… we found a paw print,” Catra said.

Glimmer sat and looked at them for a moment before it dawned on her.

“That’s amazing! I always thought that Half Moon was a myth! I can’t believe you found it!”

“It may still be,” Catra said with a shrug. “Just because we saw a paw print in some mud doesn’t mean we found a hidden civilization. It just means someone was there at one point. Maybe someone was down there trying to find a place to hide and ran

into that waterfall and drop, looked around a little more and then left and never came back."

"Yeah, you're right," Glimmer said with a sigh but then grinned. "Still, that's really amazing."

"Absolutely," Adora said. "So, you going to go exploring with us?"

"I wish! You know it's nothing but meetings all the time for me," Glimmer said. "I'd be happy to haul some stuff out for you if you want."

Adora and Catra both looked at the skiff that was still half full of gear in its compartments as well as the piles in the tent before looking back.

"You know you've missed at least one thing," Glimmer said.

"She's probably right," Catra said to Adora.

"You know I am, Fuzzy," Glimmer said as Catra stuck her tongue out at her.

"If we run into too many of those drops, we may need more rope for sure," Adora said. "I've got about a thousand feet in various

lengths but we'll have to leave them fixed behind us so we can get back up."

"Adora, if we run into many more drops like that, I think we can rule this out as Half Moon," Catra said. "Can you imagine trying to descend that with kids, sick people, old people, and the like?"

"It's doable," Adora said. "You need a lot more ropes and some other stuff but… yeah, it could be done."

"Seriously?" Catra replied.

"Yeah, I've done something similar," Adora said. "It'd be harder down there but I can see how to do it."

"Actually, just through that tunnel you enter through… yeah, you couldn't get some creaky old person down it," Catra said.

"But obviously someone went down it," Adora said.

"They had magic too," Glimmer said as she traced a quick sigil that disappeared with a sigh and a little puff of breeze. "Who knows what they did with that."

“And how do we know this is the only entrance? It’s just the one we know about,” Adora said.

“I’m not disagreeing with you all just to be contrary. I’m just trying not to get my hopes up,” Catra said.

“Whatever you find though, I think this is something most people haven’t seen in a really long time,” Glimmer said and then jumped as a screech split the evening air.

“Howler owl,” Catra and Adora both said in unison like it was no big deal and then burst out laughing at Glimmer’s face.

The next morning, Catra and Adora were up right at dawn. They both gathered up their gear and Adora started piling climbing gear into a couple of dry sacks. Catra made sure each piece went in and then they zipped it up. Then finally they made sure their personal supplies were all topped off before they slung the bags over their shoulders and went up. Some time later they emerged into the big room that Catra had named the Paw Room. They both leaned up against the wall by the entrance to take a break.

“Should have had Sparkles bring this stuff down here before she left last night,” Catra said.

“You think we should haul more stuff down here before we go down the drop?” Adora said. “We can do it in a base camp system and make this camp one.”

Catra thought for a moment as she listened to the drip of water in the darkness and then said, “Let’s see what’s beyond this drop. Then we’ll see what we’re going to do.”

Adora nodded and after a few more minutes they hauled the gear over to the drop. Adora and Catra spent time looking for a good anchor and then Adora spent time getting the rope tied off before carefully walking to the edge and looking over. When she finally tossed the rope over the edge, she couldn’t help but think that it seemed a bit final before going over to put on her climbing harness along with Catra.

“You know,” Catra said as she squatted down and then stood up while pulling the straps of the harness tight, “We absolutely did not bother to refresh ourselves on our climbing before we did this.”

Adora finished buckling her harness closed before she looked up and said, “Should we stop?”

“Naw,” Catra said. “You’ve done this recently right?”

“What? Rappelled into a pitch black pit hundreds of feet below the ground? Sure, every week,” Adora said with a grin.

“Be serious,” Catra said with a little laugh.

“I mean, yeah, I’ve done some of the climbing stuff but this feels a bit out of my experience,” Adora said. “I’m not worried. Well, not much.”

“Then let’s be extra careful,” Catra said. “No Best Friends Squad style on this one.”

“Bow would take offense at that you know,” Adora said with a laugh.

“No, he wouldn’t, because the poor guy has suffered at the hands of his wild friends, myself included, for years,” Catra said.

“OK, we’ll check everything out,” Adora said. “Check my gear and then I’ll check yours.”

After they were done with that, they both turned and looked at the hole and listened to the rush of water coming out of it.

“Which one goes first?” Adora said.

“Me,” Catra said and before Adora could comment went on. “You have more recent experience so you can check out my rig to make sure I’m set up right. If I botched it after you’ve already gone down, how would I know?”

“I could say the same thing,” Adora responded and then sighed. “This is why you have multiple people with you.”

Catra stepped over the rope and began to attach the various pieces of gear she had on to it.

“Look at this way,” Catra said. “I don’t think Rogelio would have ever fit down part of that tunnel.”

Adora shook her head as she walked over and double checked all of Catra’s attachments.

“He’s nimbler than he looks,” Adora said and then nodded. “You’re good to go. I’ll watch you go down. Flash three times on your flashlight when you get to the bottom. You got your ascender on you if you have to come back up?”

Catra held up the device hanging off the back of her harness and Adora sighed and then quickly kissed Catra.

“Be careful,” Adora said.

“I love you too. See you at the bottom,” Catra said and then slid over the side.

It wasn’t far down the rope before Catra realized that the waterfall coming out of the opposite rock face was going to make the rappel incredibly uncomfortable. There was a slight breeze coming down the drop and it was enough to cause the water to spray about a little and it wasn’t long before Catra was nice and damp. She tried not to curse as she slowly made her way down, looking down as she went.

As she got to the bottom, she could just make out a broken pile of rocks beside a pool of water that the waterfall fell into. She thought it looked like the water went over a drop on the other side of the pool but she couldn’t tell for sure. Finally, when she was sure the footing was secure, she unhooked from her rope and got her flashlight out of her pack and signaled Adora. It didn’t seem to take Adora nearly as long to get to the bottom but when she did, she looked like she’d run through a summer rain shower as well.

“That was… something,” Adora said over the noise of the falling water.

“Tell me about it!” Catra said back. “It’s going to take me forever to get dry.”

They both looked around and then Adora started walking around the edge of the pool.

“It looks like it goes over an edge over there,” Catra said, pointing at what they could both see was a narrow opening on the far side of the pool and partially behind the waterfall. The water seemed to rush over it and Catra went around Adora to take a look.

“Careful, the rocks are slippery,” Adora said.

“I know,” Catra said. “I almost wished I was barefoot but it’s cold enough. At least the boots are waterproof.”

“The wool socks help as well,” Adora said. “I know my stuff.”

“Yes, you do,” Catra said with a grin and then saw something on the wall by the drop. “Does that look like something drawn to you?”

Adora looked at where she was pointing and saw something that did look drawn. “It kind of does, yeah.”

Catra carefully made her way over to look at it and shouted back over her shoulder, “It is! Part of it is covered by flowstone but it’s some pictogram!”

As she turned back to look, she took a step to look a little closer and that’s when she fell. Adora shouted as she hit the ground but Catra just looked up at her shaking her head.

“I’m alright. Just slipped,” Catra said.

“You just about stopped my heart!” Adora said.

Catra nodded as she started to stand up on the slab of rock and that’s when she slipped into the water and the current, incredibly hard and fast, grabbed her. The last Adora saw before Catra went over the edge was her horrified face.

Chapter End Notes

What's that one meme from *The Good Place*? Oh, we're really in it now.

Also, if you're enjoying this, you should check out *Into the Planet: My Life as a Cave Diver* by Jill Heinerth. It's a non-fiction account of cave diving by one of the world class pros of it. It's about how she got into it and how she ended up testing the most advanced diving gear in the world, set world records, seen things no person had ever seen before, and the trials and tribulations along the way. I will give a content/trigger warning that there is very frank talk about death, up close and personal, in it.

The Stream

Chapter Summary

Catra has gone over a waterfall... now what!?

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"CATRA!" Adora screamed before running along the side. She could see light flailing around from below and could hear Catra screaming and shouting something. It didn't seem that far down so Adora jumped into the water and went over the edge as well. She tumbled down a smooth slope and then went into freefall before she hit the water below. It all happened in seconds and then she was floating along in a stream of water and she could see Catra crouched down holding her hand out. Adora reached out and Catra pulled her into a shallow spot in the stream.

"Did you really just do that!?" Catra said. "Did you not hear me shouting there was a way down on the other side!?"

"I was trying to save you!" Adora said. "And no! I could just hear screams and shouts!"

Catra started laughing as the two got up out of the water and into a little alcove in the wall full of sand and stones off to the side.

“Well thanks but you could have been a little more careful,” Catra said.

Adora’s heart was still pounding but she gave a rueful chuckle as she sat down beside Catra.

“That was horrifying,” Adora said and looked down the tunnel carved by the underground stream and then back towards the waterfall they’d both fallen over. “I’m calling that Catra Falls.”

Catra gave a groan at the pun and fell back.

“You obviously weren’t *that* scared if you can still pun that badly,” Catra said. “Bow would be proud.”

“I’m punning that badly *because* I’m scared,” Adora said.

“I’m sorry I scared you,” Catra said as she took her helmet off and set it on the sand where it would illuminate the both of them.

“Don’t be sorry,” Adora said. “It was an accident. I’m just glad it wasn’t bad.”

Catra was taking her boots off and grumbling a little as she did.

“What’s wrong?” Adora said, thinking Catra had maybe hurt her foot. Then she watched as Catra dumped a load of water out of her boot.

“They’re waterproof, remember? Means water doesn’t get out either,” Catra said.

“I’ll have to tell the company they’re waterproof until you decide to drop them into the water,” Adora said.

“And I’m not just grumbling about the shoes,” Catra said. “I’m soaked. I am not happy right now.”

“Need a hug?” Adora said.

“No. I love you but the last thing I want right now is your clammy self on me,” Catra said.

Adora gave a little chuckle as she took her helmet off, shut off the light, and ran her fingers through her soaked hair. “Well, thank goodness for waterproof packs. We better eat something to get a little energy and then figure out if we can get back up.”

Catra looked down the stream running off into the dark and said, “Don’t you want to figure out how to keep going?”

"OK, I'm surprised to hear that from you but if you want to, yeah, we can. First though, we need to make sure we can get out," Adora said. "We don't have to be done for the day but like I said, I'm surprised you want to keep going."

"I'm coming to terms with these banal sufferings and as much as I hate it, well, I want to see where this goes," Catra said. "Besides, sitting outside afterwards it just feels… fulfilling, I guess is the word."

Adora was rummaging in her pack as she said, "One of my crew talked about some of the hardships we go through and how we look back fondly on them. Said it's like hitting yourself in the hand with a hammer because it feels so good when you stop."

Catra laughed as she said, "Are you sure you're not the crew member?"

Adora handed her the bag full of peanuts, chocolate, and dried fruit as she said, "Says the one who just made the comment. And no, it wasn't me, it was Rosehip."

Catra thought of the towering wall of person that was Rosehip, with chipped horns, scars, and the softest smile, and nodded.

“She’s definitely been through it so I’d say she knows what she’s talking about.”

They sat in the light of the single headlamp, the noise of water rushing past them as they both looked at the rippled stone as time seemed to stand still for them. Adora packed away the snack after she realized neither of them had touched it in a while and finally Catra spoke up.

“We need to check out that way back. I really want to move forward if we have the time,” Catra said.

Adora pulled out her miniature data pad and checked.

“Yep, still plenty of time,” she said and then took a couple of pictures of the waterfall and the underground stream and tapped at the pad for a moment. Catra picked up her helmet and then turned to Adora.

“Hey, don't turn that back on, I want to try something,” Catra said. Adora nodded. Catra waited for a second and then shut off her light, plunging them into complete darkness.

“Catra!” Adora shouted suddenly.

“Sorry, should have warned you, I wanted to see how dark it looked,” Catra said, her voice coming out of the blackness. Adora

looked around, closing her eyes and opening them and didn't see any difference. The darkness seemed almost to press in on them.

"OK, I won't lie, that's kind of cool," she said as she held her hand as close to her face as she could without touching it. She couldn't see it of course but it had just felt like she should have been able to.

"I know, right?" Catra said. "I'm going to turn it back on now."

"Go for it," Adora said and then blinked in the sudden light as it came back on.

Adora got her helmet back on and they both got ready to move again as they discussed how to cross the stream to the other side. Adora used one of her flashlights in her pack to illuminate the other side.

"OK, so by the waterfall it's definitely deep enough we can't touch," Catra said. "I think we cross back here. That little beach thing over there seems like it runs right up to the ramp on the other side."

Adora played her light up and down and nodded.

"I agree," she said. "I'll go up towards the waterfall and start trying to cross there. You stay back here and catch me if I slip."

Catra nodded and they began the crossing. Adora found as she got further from the waterfall, the water wasn't as deep and assumed it had carved out a deep pool under it after centuries of the water falling against the rock. She kept running into a deep channel in the center though that went deeper than her feet could feel though. Finally, she took a deep breath, felt the current to make sure it wasn't too heavy, and made a quick paddle across. She was pleased to find it only took a few strokes and she once again felt her boots touch bottom. It wasn't long before she was standing on the opposite shore. When she turned around she realized it wasn't even that far and she didn't even have to raise her voice much.

"Alright! That's where you cross!"

Catra nodded and took a deep breath when she saw Adora make it. She moved up to where Adora had been and thought about how they really should have roped up. If she slipped on this side, Adora would have to dive in after her instead of waiting on the bank to get her and shook her head as she realized the little stupid risks they kept taking. She pushed them out of her head though and concentrated on getting into the water, suppressing a little shudder as she did every time she had to get into water, and was soon across with Adora.

"You alright?" Adora said.

"Yeah," Catra said, running through a quick anxiety-reducing routine in her head as she pushed away thoughts of a green pool.

“Water and I have an understanding, it’s gotten easier, but I don’t think it’s ever going to be fun. I’m still going forward though.”

Adora bumped her helmet against Catra’s and smiled. Catra grinned back and the two started walking back towards the falls. They stood at the base of a sloping stone face as they both ran their lights over it, trying to figure out how to get up it. Adora spotted it first.

“Hey, you see that?” she said, putting her light on a small hole about four feet up from where the stone ran under the sand.

“Yep, what is that?” Catra responded and then saw another one about four feet higher and another one above that one. They both looked up the rock and saw the holes repeating all the way up the slope to the top.

“What in the world would form that?” Adora said as Catra leaned on the rock and stuck her finger in one and felt it.

“A drill,” Catra said as she stood back up.

“What do you mean… oh,” Adora said as it dawned on her.

“Yeah, that rock is fairly smooth and you could probably go up by working up the side there but wouldn’t it be easier to install some

kind of system using poles you could pull yourself between?" Catra said.

They both stood there as they realized exactly what it was they'd found out. Adora finally pulled out her miniature data pad and took a picture and then a closeup of the first hole with her hand next to it. While she did that, Catra walked back and forth at the base of the slope, looking at the slope, thinking about who'd been there before them or at least who she thought may have been there. Then, back against the wall, she put her foot down and felt the ground shift a little and a muffled clink sound.

"Adora? I think we got something here," Catra said as she got down on her hands and knees and dug into the sand. Adora came over quickly as Catra uncovered a six foot metal pole as she moved the sand off of it, she found more, and then nestled among it all, a fabric bag that was rotting away but full of thick wire.

"What is that?" Adora said as she snapped photos.

"Isn't it obvious?" Catra said with a grin as she pointed at a hole drilled near the top of one of the poles and then the wire. "It's a railing system. It must have got left here."

Adora went quiet as she saw Catra's face fall a little.

“It got left here and then buried by floods,” Catra said. “Which means we’re not going towards a hidden town. We’re probably going towards what’s left of it.”

She sighed as Adora put a hand on her shoulder.

“Did you think someone had stayed down here all these centuries?” Adora said quietly.

“No, I really didn’t but you know a small part of me did,” Catra said and then looked around. “Probably for the best. As much cool stuff that we’ve seen, I’d hate to stay in here for my whole life.”

“Then let’s get going and see if we can figure out what happened,” Adora said.

Catra nodded and they gathered up all the poles and wire and then they started working up the slope. The poles went in about a foot and a half and then hit the bottom. They ran the wire through the holes and when they were done, even though a few of the poles seemed to be missing, they had a line of them up the stone to the top that they could use to move up and down the slippery rock. As they sat at the top of the waterfall, Catra felt a sense of accomplishment, not only for herself but also for whatever distant hypothetical ancestor of hers who came up with this idea.

Adora had walked away and realized that this edge of the bottom of the pit was a bit higher than the other side and she found a way behind the big waterfall that fell from the top of the pit and over to their rope. She walked back and sat down next to Catra.

"OK, we can get back to the rope," Adora said. "So we have a decision. Do we push forward for a few more hours or head back now? I say we push forward and figure out a bit more and then head back out."

Catra nodded as she said, "That's what I want to do as well."

"We're going to be in the water a lot," Adora said.

"I know. I'll cope. I want to see where this goes," Catra said. "If it goes too much further… well, we did plan to stay down here for days. We need to start staging equipment for ourselves though. We haven't touched my food or much of my water. If I still have it untouched when we get back here, I'm going to make a cache of it so we can pick it up when we come back through."

"That sounds like a good idea," Adora replied. "I've got a water filter back at camp. I'll leave all my water bottles except for one here as well and then we can top them off from the water here when we come back. It'll get a little wonky but I think we can haul them with more."

“OK, tonight when we get out, we’ll plan some more, maybe take a break day and then the next time we come back in we’re coming in with as much stuff as we can haul and make a serious push,” Catra said.

Adora thought for a second and then gave a little nod.

“Agreed. Well, you ready to push forward and see some more before we turn around?”

Catra looked at the metal poles and wire going down the slope and grinned.

“Let’s push on.”

Chapter End Notes

> Don't jump over underground waterfalls everyone. That said, I remember when I wrote that bit where Catra is thinking of all the little risk they're taking and just felt that deep down. I've done the same and sometimes you think it's little until you realize, when something happens to someone else, just how big that risk actually was that you took.

The Climb

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora push on into the cave, trying to see just how far they can get.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They made their way to the bottom of the slope and Catra stood at the edge of the water, taking a few breaths as she watched Adora wade into the water and start walking. After a moment, she followed along. They followed the edge of the stream until it narrowed down into another cramped tunnel. Catra watched as blooms of silt got kicked up off the bottom and the clear water immediately became cloudy as they pushed forward. The ceiling was only a few feet over their heads as they felt the push of the water behind them. They slogged along, water above their waists, until they came to a section where the tunnel roof sloped down and met the water. Adora turned around and looked at Catra.

"Uh, I think we've hit an end," Adora said.

"Should have brought Mermista with us," Catra said as she pushed up next to Adora and felt along the wall.

"She does have experience in narrow underground waterways, although this place is way cleaner than the Fright Zone sewers," Adora said.

Catra felt a lip of rock hanging down under the water and thought she could feel it going straight back up. A little thought popped into her head and she thought she had lost her mind when she turned to Adora.

"I think this just goes under a lip and then back out into air on the other side," Catra said.

"And?" Adora replied.

Catra took a deep breath and then said, "And I want you to attach a rope to me and I'm going to dive under and see if I can come back up."

Adora sat there shocked for a moment before she said, "Absolutely not! Have you lost your mind!? If anyone is going to do that, it's going to be me!"

Catra was wondering if she had but she shook her head as she said, "No, it's gotta be me. I want you on the other end of the line, with She-Ra powered muscles if necessary, to haul me back out if it goes bad."

Adora was shaking her head, her face full of fear, as she said, "Look how tight it is right here, you think I've got room to fit She-Ra in this space?"

“As if you won’t make room,” Catra said with a tight grin.

“I don’t like this at all,” Adora said. “I really think we need to re-think this. We may have just hit the end.”

“Adora, I love you. Now we can argue in this freezing water and at the end you can get the rope out and help me get linked in or you can get the rope out and help me get linked into it now,” Catra said. “I’m going to see what’s on the other side of this.”

Adora took a deep breath, wanting to argue it but finally just nodded and helped Catra get out of her pack and tied off a length of rope to her harness. They worked out a few signals and just how long Adora should wait before hauling Catra back in. As they sat there, Catra started to take a few deep breaths and Adora had her hand on her shoulder and could feel her shaking a little.

“You sure about this?” Adora said. Catra looked at her with fear in her eyes and wasn’t able to say anything but just nodded and then disappeared under the water. Adora held the rope and felt it feed out as Catra went forward. She felt helpless as all she could do was watch Catra’s pack float on the water next to her and feel the rope move.

Catra went under and felt the lip of the rock. Even with her headlamp on, all she could see in the silty water was a faint glow so she finally closed her eyes. She felt her heart slamming like a hammer in her ribs as she fought to keep calm submerged under

the water. She slipped under the lip of the rock and felt it sloping up slightly as she went along it and only seconds later she broke the water's surface on the other side, her face hard against the ceiling but in the light of her lamp she could see it quickly opened up into what looked like another room. She felt a rush of euphoria as she realized she'd made it and took a few deep breaths and then went back under again before Adora dragged her back. Going back was harder against the current but it wasn't long before she popped up out of the water in front of Adora.

"It goes! It's a big room just on the other side of this rock!" Catra shouted in excitement. Adora wrapped her in her arms as they both trembled with excitement and released fear.

"Do not ever do that again," Adora whispered. Even though it'd been barely a minute, Adora had felt like it'd taken an eternity before Catra had appeared beside her.

"Hey, Adora, it's alright," Catra said, bumping their helmets together.

"I know, it's just… it was scary," Adora said.

"I'm sorry. If it's any consolation, I bet I'm not going to sleep tonight, I'm so jacked up on adrenaline," Catra said.

"It's not," Adora said. "But at least we'll be up together because I'm feeling the same."

"OK, well get this rope off me and let's go check this out," Catra said. "Might as well if we're going to be horrified together later."

After some splashing and work they got everything stowed and they both dove and came out the other side. The pool of water they floated in was in the middle of what they could tell was another big room. This one wasn't quite as high ceiled or as wide as the last big one but was full of formations. They crawled up out of the pool and looked at the room as they saw it twist off into the distance.

"OK, this… I think I'm tapped out for today," Adora finally said as they both caught their breath.

Catra looked, felt the urge to push forward but finally begrudgingly nodded.

"Yeah, I think we go back before we're too tired to go forward or back," Catra said.

After a short break, they found going back up stream was more difficult and by the time they came back out of the water by the poles in the rock, they were both bone tired. They made their way up the slope and over to the rope. Catra and Adora unloaded all but a bottle of water for each of them and left all their food at the base of the rope as a cache for the next time they were through.

They got the ascender equipment out and Adora got her's attached to the rope and tied in backup safety knots. She flicked the switch on the ascender as Catra backed up so she wouldn't be under any falling rocks if Adora accidentally dislodged any. Then nothing happened.

"Why aren't you moving?" Catra said.

"I don't know," Adora said as she fiddled with the little device that was supposed to pull her up the rope. "It's just not working."

Catra came back over as she said, "We checked these out. They worked just fine." Then a horrible thought occurred to her. "Are they waterproof?"

"Yes," Adora said. "I've used them in pouring rain."

"Yes, but have you used them after submerging them for long periods in an underground stream?" Catra responded.

Adora thought about it for a moment before she said, "No, I haven't. They're supposed to be able to be submerged but…"

She trailed off as they both looked up into the darkness stretching out above their heads. Catra pulled her ascender out and turned it on. It whirred for a few moments and they both relaxed and then it stopped as well. They both stared at each other for a long

moment before Catra finally said, “Are we going to have to climb that rope hand over hand?”

Adora slowly shook her head as she thought and then said, “Kind of. There’s a knot I know that we can tie. We tie two of them and slide them up the rope while keeping the other under tension. It takes… well, it takes a really long time. I’ve only done it once.”

“Did they teach us that in our mountain training and I’ve just forgot?” Catra said.

“No, one of my crew knew how to do it and showed me,” Adora said. “I went about seven feet up to a tree branch just to see how it works.”

Catra covered her face with her hand before she sighed and nodded. “Well unless you have another idea it’s that or have She-Ra throw me to the top so let’s do it.”

Adora got out the cord and webbing she needed and walked over to Catra.

“Whoa, I’m not going first!” Catra said.

“Yes, you are,” Adora said. “Because I don’t want to teach you how to tie it and then hope you do it right when I’m not here to watch.”

"But… fine. Let's just get it over with," Catra said.

Adora ran her through the procedure several times and then got Catra attached to the rope. Catra gave her a brief kiss and then Adora stood back and watched as Catra started making her way slowly up the rope. Time held still and Adora knew there wasn't a whole lot she could do at the moment but she couldn't take her eyes off Catra as she went from a defined figure in the dark to a lone dot of light surrounded by pitch blackness slowly ascending up the side of the cliff face.

Catra was exhausted when she got to the top. She'd stopped several times for a moment to rest but it was still physically taxing and on top of everything else that had happened that day, she knew she was running low. She came over the edge and went forward a few feet before laying down on the rope. Then she finally got herself unclipped from the rope and shouted at the top of her lungs, "Off rope!"

The words echoed in the dark and she strained to hear if Adora responded. When there was no response she carefully went to the edge and tried to look down. She shouted again as loud as she could but she wasn't sure Adora could hear her and if she could, Catra was pretty sure she couldn't hear Adora. She tried to think of what to do when the rope started twitching and she realized Adora was starting up. It wasn't long before she saw the little speck of light in the pitch blackness below her that was Adora.

Catra felt like she didn't breathe the whole time it took Adora to get to the top of the rope. Catra reached out and took her hand

as she came over and helped her get over the lip of the drop. Just like Catra had, Adora lay down with a sigh before finally getting unattached from the rope.

"That. Was. Terrible," Adora said as Catra sat next to her.

"Tell me about it," she said. "And now we have the joy of going ALL the way back through those tight twisty tunnels."

"Should we just camp here overnight?" Adora said.

"Absolutely not," Catra said. "I want dry clothes and a chance to dry myself out. Besides, we left all our food at the bottom, remember?"

Adora sighed as she said, "Oh yeah, there's that." She rummaged around in her bag and took out a small energy bar. "Split it?"

"I have never been happier with you for holding something back," Catra said as Adora broke it in half and held out both pieces for Catra to choose from.

"I didn't. That's my emergency energy bar," Adora said. "It's been sitting in the bottom of my pack for who knows how long."

Catra kept chewing and shrugged.

"Tastes fine."

They both emerged from the cave not long afterwards at about the same time they say Glimmer and Bow suddenly appear down in their base camp. They waved and got Glimmer's attention and she teleported over to them with Bow.

"You two look *terrible,"* Glimmer said.

"Oh, good, I was worried I'd look fantastic after all of that," Catra said.

"Are you OK?" Bow said. "We got worried. You missed your check in time."

Adora pulled out her miniature data pad and looked at it.

"Only by a little bit," she said.

"Only by two hours," Glimmer said. "I should have come out right after you missed it."

“We’re fine, just exhausted. Sparkles, I will let you teleport me just this once if it means I don’t have to climb down to camp,” Catra said.

“You must be close to death then if you’re willing to put up with that,” Glimmer said with a grin before getting them all down to the tent. Catra shook the disorientation of the teleport off as she started to shed her harness. Adora took her miniature data pad out and immediately hooked it up to her bigger data pad.

“What happened down there?” Bow said.

“Let me sum it up,” Adora said. “Catra fell over a waterfall, dove under a wall that was underwater without knowing what’s on the other side, and we definitely found proof someone has been in there before us.”

“Don’t forget our gear not working. That’s probably why we ran past our check in,” Catra said as she went into the tent and a sodden filthy shirt came flying out.

“Oh, yeah, my ascenders didn’t work,” Adora said as she tossed one onto the camp table. “I think they failed from getting soaked. We waded a stream for some distance. I’ll be having a fun talk with the company. They’re supposed to be waterproof.”

Bow picked one up and started messing with it while he said, “Well, I’m glad you were alright. We were worried.”

“Sorry about that,” Adora said. “We went as quick as we could.”

“Just out of curiosity, what was your plan if you came out and didn’t find us?” Catra said as she came out in a loose tank top and shorts with a towel. She flopped down in a chair with a sigh as she worked on drying off her mane. Adora looked around at the pile of equipment and clothes leading into the tent and then to Catra.

“I rescind my offer to let you come on a survey with me,” Adora said.

“I’ll pick it up as soon as I’ve had a breather. Stop fiddling with that data pad and get out of that gear. You can’t be comfortable,” Catra said.

“OK, before you two start getting into your little back and forth, let me at least respond,” Glimmer said.

“Wait, we didn’t pull you away from your Dad’s did we, Bow?” Adora said suddenly. Bow looked up from where he’d already disassembled one of the ascenders.

“What? Oh, that. No, it’s good,” Bow said.

“Like I was saying,” Glimmer said, giving all three of them a look. “We figured we’d get out here, figure out what happened, and go in after you if we had to.”

“Have you ever teleported into a place like that?” Catra said.

“No, but I would if I had to,” Glimmer said.

Adora hit a button then and said, “Well, I’ll upload this to you so you can be more accurate if you have to be.”

Adora held up her data pad and they all saw the cave mapped out as a huge constellation of dots.

“How in the world did you pull that off?” Catra said as Adora finally set the data pad down and started to get out of her harness.

Adora pointed at the headlamp on her helmet and said, “Scanner built in. We both have them. The more we move through a space, the more accurate it is.”

The three looked at Adora and she said, “What? I wanted to map the thing. Why do you think I’m carrying around a data pad down there anyway?”

“I just assumed photos but this is good,” Catra said. “At least if we get lost, they’ll know where we might be.”

Glimmer had picked up the data pad and had zoomed in on several points. She saw the dimensions on the tunnels as the data pad helpfully annotated them and gave an estimate of how accurate it was and said, “Don’t get lost. That looks horrifying.”

“Ah, it’s not THAT bad once you get used to it,” Catra said as she continued to towel off. “The water isn’t any fun, I’ll tell you that for free though.”

Adora went into the tent, picking up her gear and Catra’s gear as she went and said, “Well I’m glad you didn’t have to. Thank you for coming out though. It’s nice to know you got our back.”

“You know we always do,” Bow said with a smile. “By the way, I figured out what was wrong with this thing. The case sealing the electronics has a little flaw in it. It doesn’t look like damage, it just looks like it wasn’t adequately sealed. Probably never been a problem before because most people probably don’t drag them through rivers. I can get it fixed if you want.”

Adora came out in a long t-shirt and shorts and flopped down next to Catra.

“If you could, I’d appreciate it. We had to manually go up a two hundred and twenty feet of rope,” Adora said.

“I might even be able to build a better one if you could wait a day or so,” Bow said.

“You don’t have to do that,” Catra said.

“No, really. I bet I can find some designs on one of the data boards and Bright Moon has great 3D printer and fabrication setups. If you don’t mind testing them out, I could have them to you tomorrow,” Bow said.

“We could use that day to bring supplies and gear in for the big push,” Adora said to Catra. “Stage it at the top of Paw Print Pit.”

Catra nodded and agreed as Glimmer began rummaging around in the skiff as she said, “I’m making you all dinner too since we’re obviously becoming the support team for you both.”

Adora laughed and Catra said, “Normally I’d argue with you but it’s good to be sitting above ground and comfortable so I’ll take it.”

Chapter End Notes

> So I've been doing a lot of quick little fact checks on caves, getting my knowledge refreshed as I write, and I wanted to share this little bit I found. There are MANY different types of caves and many different ways of forming them. I thought

someone might find this as interesting as I did so I included a link below.

National Caves Association: Types of Caves

Into The Long Dark

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora start their big multi-day push into the cave.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next day Catra and Adora returned to the cave after making plans with Bow and Glimmer over dinner. They had several bags full of gear and food and pushed and pulled them through the tunnels to the top of Paw Print Pit. It was a long and exhausting day. The next night, Bow and Glimmer visited again and Bow handed over the new ascenders.

"Just pulled them out of the fabricator before we left," Bow said. Adora laughed at Catra's face as Catra picked up the pale purple devices with the emblem of Bright Moon on their side.

"Just had to do the Bright Moon colors didn't you?" Catra said.

"The fabricator will do different colors but I figured it'd be easier to leave it on the default," Bow said with a grin. Catra shook her head as she stood up and grabbed a rope bag sitting close to her.

"Wait! Are you going to go and test it right now!?" Glimmer said.

“Yes, but you can get that look off your face, I’m doing it off a tree,” Catra said as she grabbed her harness as well. “Adora, come along and scare off any Howler Owls you might see would you?”

The four went along as Catra looked for a tall tree, their eyes all looking for the shape of one of the Howler Owls. Finally, Catra found a large tree, got into her harness, and went up the tree with the rope. She got to a high branch with a drop under it and got the rope situated so it hung down. As she was about to go back down, she heard a little rustling in the tree behind her. She turned around to see a Howler Owl, crouched low along a branch, stalking her.

“Buddy, you do not want to mess with me,” Catra said quietly. It sat and blinked for a moment and then let out its screech. Catra arched her back, her tail poofed out as she hissed back at it, teeth exposed and claws gripping the branch.

The animal quickly scurried back and out of sight as Adora shouted out from below, “Are you OK!?”

Catra came back down the rope quickly as she said, “Yeah, Howler Owl thought I was an easy mark.”

Glimmer was laughing as she said, “Well, that thing won’t be back.”

“Hopefully not,” Catra said as she got the ascender attached. Bow checked it for her as he told her how it worked and Adora looked over his shoulder. Catra nodded and switched it on and up the rope she went at a decent pace. She got about ten feet off the ground before she turned it off and just hung off it.

“I ran it through the same kind of simulation program we did for opening that portal to Angella and it should have worked out all the flaws,” Bow said.

“That would make me feel better if that thing hadn’t almost been a complete and total nightmare where all of us were almost wiped out,” Adora said.

“But that was way more complicated,” Bow said. “This is easy.”

“Maybe don’t tell them the program next time,” Glimmer said with a grin. Catra reversed the ascender so it wouldn’t hold her in place and slid back down to them.

“OK, Bow, I trust you so I’m going to trust this,” Catra said. “You sure this thing is waterproof?”

“Yep,” Bow said. “All the circuits are from Salineas. They know their waterproofing. As soon as you’re done with this, I’m putting the improved design up for free on the data boards.”

“Sure you don’t want to try and sell them?” Adora said.

“Why? It’s not really my design. It’s based on at least a dozen other peoples' work who all put it in for free. This is just me giving back to the Etherian maker’s community,” Bow said.

“Besides, it might junk out on us half way up a drop and you don’t want your name all over that,” Catra said.

“It’ll work,” Bow said, looking a bit affronted at the assumption.

Catra slung her arm around him as she said, “I know it will. You are the tech master after all.”

That night they sat around the camp again talking about what was going to happen. Catra cooked while the three sat around the table and as Adora laid out the plan Catra and her had come up with over the day.

“We’re going to take tomorrow off to rest,” Adora said as she pulled up the map on her data pad. “Then we’re going to make a big multi-day push. We can get to the top of Paw Print Pit pretty quick and that’s Camp One. We’ve got food, water, water filters, and first aid staged at the top. When we go down again, we’re bringing even more equipment. We’ll pick up more from Camp One, leaving enough behind to cover us on our way back out, and then push forward. We still have that cache at the bottom of Paw

Print Pit as well and we'll make sure it's good before going past Catra Falls and down the stream."

"You're really going to use that name aren't you?" Glimmer said.

"Hey, I fell over that thing. It deserves to bear my name," Catra said as she shook a little seasoning into the pot.

"Back on subject," Adora said with a shake of her head. "We go down the stream, under the overhang, and we'll explore Room Two."

"Why is that Room Two?" Bow said. "Shouldn't it be Room Four?"

"I guess but we've already called the first one the Entry Room, that small one just after The Slide doesn't really have a name yet and isn't really big like the other rooms, and Paw Room has a name. So for now, it's Room Two because that's what makes sense to me."

Bow nodded as he sat back and Adora went on.

"Then we'll see where we go from there. We'll camp in Room Two if it turns out to be too large to cover but I think somewhere past that is going to be Camp Two and where we'll spend night one. We press on from there and if we don't find something by night

two, or just come up against something we can't deal with, we turn around," Adora said.

"And if you find Half Moon?" Bow said.

"You'll hear my shouts through solid rock," Catra said with a grin as she carried the pot to the table.

"I don't like you both going down there for so long and not being in contact," Glimmer said. "I wish we had a way to talk with you."

"Bow and I were kicking that around," Adora said. "We can't talk but if I could get you to place some receivers around the area, I can at least send a distress signal. It won't be much, the rock is going to absorb pretty much anything, but I'll set my data pad up here to monitor for the tone and send out a call for help."

"If I had more time, I know I could make something pocket size," Bow said. "Something that could be sensed anywhere on the planet no matter what."

"Sorry, Arrow Boy, but I want to get this over with," Catra said as she finished dishing up the food and everyone started eating. "As interesting as this is, well, the water, the dark, the tight spaces…,"

"I get it," Bow replied with a nod.

That night, after Glimmer and Bow had gone home after a little more work after dinner and some talk, Catra and Adora were laid out on their cots staring at the ceiling of the tent and listening to the noises outside. They had made the decision not to wait a day and to go down in the morning. They held each other's hands tight and finally Adora broke the silence.

"I'm kind of scared," she said.

"Me too," Catra said.

"Should we really be doing this?" Adora said. "I mean, we've proved someone was down there a long time ago. Maybe we need to wait until we can get more people."

"We've got a good plan," Catra said, not feeling very confident in the dark.

"I know. I just keep thinking of you going over that waterfall and…," Adora trailed off.

"Yeah, I know," Catra said as she rolled over. "I won't promise you that it'll be alright but I'll promise you that I'll be as careful as I can be. I want to know what's down there but not at the expense of losing you."

Adora leaned over and they kissed briefly before she leaned back.

"Gotta get a cot large enough for the both of us," Adora said as she ruefully rubbed her ribs where the edges of both cots had dug in. Then she got serious. "I promise you the same thing though. We'll be as careful as we can be."

They went to sleep watching each other and woke up bright and early. They made what they figured would be their last really hot meal in four days and got the rest of their equipment ready. The sky was barely light as they made their way to the entrance. They both stood at the entrance, watching the last of the night fade away and the high clouds above them.

"We should have waited until it was lighter," Adora said.

"Wouldn't have mattered," Catra said, thinking of the utter blackness of the cave.

Adora was about to say that she had wanted that memory before they faced the long dark of the cave when she realized how melodramatic she was feeling. She turned to Catra with a grin.

"Mara, we're being dramatic. We've got this."

Catra looked back at her and broke into a matching grin.

“Yeah, we do,” Catra said. “Come on. Sooner we’re down, sooner we get back to see the light.”

Soon they were at the top of Paw Print Pit and they began to ferry equipment to the bottom. They left a cache as planned at the top and soon they both went over the edge. They gathered up the gear, checked the cache they’d left at the bottom, and were soon sloshing down the stream with their equipment. As they got close to the part they’d have to dive under, Adora could hear Catra muttering to herself.

“You OK back there?” Adora said, looking back over her shoulder.

“Just doing a little destress exercise,” Catra said.

“Perfuma would be proud of you,” Adora said.

“Yeah, yeah, I’m not doing it for *her,”* Catra said with a rueful smile.

Adora dove first this time and stayed on the other side while Catra shoved the waterproof bags under the lip and then let them go. Adora caught them as they came rocketing to the surface and got them attached together. When the last bag came through, Catra took a few deep breaths, did her best to calm her nerves, and

dove. Adora saw the water lit up by Catra's headlamp a few seconds before she broke the surface.

"That will never be fun," Catra said.

"I still can't believe you did it without knowing there was air on the other side," Adora said.

"I know, don't remind me," Catra said as they made their way to shore. They stacked up the gear and began to look around. The room was full of formations of beautiful colored stones. They found a small isolated pool full of what looked like pearls and they spent a few minutes admiring it before they pushed on. The pool they'd surfaced in narrowed back down to a stream and they saw the room meandered back and forth as if it followed the stream.

"We better get the rest of the gear; this looks like it goes a ways," Adora said. They followed the room for hundreds of yards until they heard what sounded like another waterfall.

"I'll stay away from it," Catra said as she saw Adora look at her.

"I wasn't going to say anything," Adora said with a chuckle.

It wasn't long before they got to the end of the room to see the stream disappearing down a drop but more impressive was the multitude of tunnels at different levels of the back wall. A few of

the tunnels weren't very large but at least one of them was tall enough for them to walk into without stooping over.

"What in the world caused *this?"* Adora said.

"Shifting of the stream maybe?" Catra said. "Maybe something made burrows."

Adora turned to her, thinking of the giant guardian under Bright Moon, as she said, "That is not funny."

Catra grinned as she said, "It's kind of funny but before you freak yourself out, nothing that large could survive down here. No food."

"Catra, something even bigger than those tunnels is alive under Bright Moon castle," Adora said. "And I can promise you, it lives just fine down there."

"Well, I think we would have run into something like that by now so again, I think we're fine," Catra responded.

"I hope so," Adora said, grumbling.

"How do we know which one is the right way?" Catra said.

“I don’t know,” Adora said. “I think we just hit Camp Two to be honest. We’ve been going for a while now. Let’s stage a cache here, set up for an overnight, and then start poking around in these until we’re tired and ready to lay down.”

“Deal,” Catra said.

They picked a spot and piled up the gear and had something to eat. Catra’s eyes kept straying towards the waterfall not too far away as Adora ate with one hand and worked on her miniature data pad with the other.

“Will you stop looking at that thing please? You’re kind of freaking me out,” Adora said without looking up.

“How do you even know I’m looking at anything?” Catra said.

Adora looked up as she said, “Because every time you move your head, the shadows shift in here because your headlamp moves.”

Catra laughed as she realized that was true.

“Sorry, I was just thinking about how glad I am that neither one of us is a sleepwalker,” Catra said.

Adora looked over and then started laughing as well.

"That'd be one terrible way to wake up."

She turned back to Catra and gave a little smile at her.

"Can I take your picture real quick?"

"Why? I'm filthy and sodden."

"Because your pupils are enormous and frankly, it's beautiful," Adora said. Catra got shy but nodded and Adora took the picture. They both looked at it and felt a little better about the whole thing.

"Alright, fair's fair. I want one of you now," Catra said and Adora handed over the data pad for her to take the picture.

After a little longer resting, they finally stood with a stretch and began to check the tunnels. Adora left a survey stake at the entrance of each one they entered. They tried the smaller ones first, just to get the tight squeezes over with, and found that they all narrowed down to tighter than they could manage pretty quickly. Backing out wasn't fun but they managed.

Catra was the one who found the pit though. They'd gone in a large tunnel above and to the left of where the water disappeared into the wall and had to climb part of it before it started sloping down. It'd tightened up a little and Catra had gone first.

"Adora, I can turn around easier than you if I have to," Catra said. "Just wait until I shout that you can come down."

"Good point," Adora said. "Alright, I'll wait here."

Adora lay down in the tunnel, which was easier than trying to find a sitting position with the low ceiling, and turned her headlamp off as she watched Catra's light go down the tunnel. She found herself drifting a little when suddenly she heard Catra shout something. She jerked upright and immediately bashed her helmet on the ceiling and shouted herself at the impact.

Catra, further down the tunnel, heard Adora shout and was doing her best to not freak out a little. She was sitting at the edge of a drop that she couldn't see the bottom of. She'd come around a corner and the tunnel had widened just a bit before it'd suddenly dropped away. She could hear water from below her but when she'd looked over the edge, she'd only seen the wall dropping away. She'd shouted back to Adora but the only response she'd gotten was Adora's incoherent shouting. When she got turned around and went back up the tunnel, she'd almost run straight into Adora coming the other way.

“Are you ok!?” Adora said as they almost bonked heads coming around a corner.

“I could ask you the same,” Catra said.

“Sorry, I was drifting off and heard your shout,” Adora said. “Jerked upright and hit my helmet on the ceiling.”

“You and bashing your head into things,” Catra said, shaking her head. “We found our stopping point for the day by the way.”

“What do you mean?” Adora said.

“This thing goes down, takes a turn and then almost dumps you over the edge into a pit,” Catra said. “I couldn’t see how deep it was.”

“OK, yeah, that sounds like a stopping point,” Adora said.

“Especially if you’re falling asleep,” Catra said.

“You would be too,” Adora said. “There’s something relaxing about total darkness and very little noise.”

“Yeah, no, I’m good. Turn around and let’s go get some rest,” Catra said.

“In just a minute. I want to go see this pit,” Adora said.

“Adora, it’ll be there after we rested,” Catra said.

“I’m not going down it. I just want to see how deep it is,” Adora said. “I need to know if we have enough rope.”

“OK, but you’re still going to have to turn around,” Catra said.

“You could crawl over me,” Adora said.

“Or you could turn around! Come on!” Catra said.

“OK, OK,” Adora said and started backing up until she managed to get turned around. When they got out, Adora waited for Catra to get out and then started back in.

“Be careful,” Catra said. “It’s kind of sudden.”

“I will,” Adora said as she disappeared up the tunnel. Catra sat down at their pile of gear that consisted of their camp and sighed as she waited. Her eyes started drooping by the time Adora got back.

“OK, it’s ridiculous deep,” Adora said. “The data pad puts it at just over 150 meters or about 500 feet deep.”

“Wait, we don’t have rope that long,” Catra said.

“I know but it kept giving me a weird reading,” Adora said. “I finally figured out why. I think there’s a ledge about two hundred feet down. We can go down to that and see if we can find an anchor and then go the rest of the way. We have enough rope to reach that.”

“And if there isn’t a ledge?”

“Well then that’s what the ascenders are for,” Adora said. “We’ll put a stopper knot at the end and attach a few pieces of equipment before that. If I hit those, we know to turn around.”

“I see you’re assuming you’re going first,” Catra said.

“Found an anchor and everything,” Adora said.

“OK, we’ll argue it out in the morning,” Catra said. “Let’s get some rest.”

Catra pulled out a woven plastic ground cloth and spread it out on the ground and the two laid down together using gear bags for pillows, only taking time to take off their harnesses. Adora snapped a red chem-light as they turned off their headlamps. The faint glow of the stick soon seemed incredibly bright in the pitch blackness. Adora threw her arm over Catra and the two were asleep without even realizing it.

Chapter End Notes

> If you’re wondering, the deepest pit in a cave on Earth is in Slovenia at a cave called Vrtoglavica Cave. It’s a depth of 603 m (1,978 ft) deep according to Wikipedia. That’s about ⅓ of a mile deep or a bit over ½ a kilometer. The deepest in the Western Hemisphere is 333 m (1,094 ft) at Sótano de Las Golondrinas cave in Mexico. The little drop of about five hundred feet Catra and Adora are facing is pretty comparable to the deepest pits in the United States. If you want to read about pit caves, here's a link to get started: Wikipedia: Pit Caves.

Places in the Dark

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora push on, further into the cave, and discover something in the blackness.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up first and had no idea how long she'd been asleep. She felt refreshed but with no idea if it was morning or still night in the little circle of red light thrown by the chem-light in the darkness. She sat up with a little muffled groan as she stretched a little, felt dried mud flaking off her fur, and shuddered a little.

"I must have been tired," she muttered to herself as she pulled her shirt off and ran her fingers through the fur on her arm, trying to knock the worst of the dried mud off. Adora woke up and smiled.

"Ah, my beautiful wife," she said.

"Your incredibly filthy wife," Catra said. "You're not much better to be honest."

"I'm telling you, hot springs at Mystacor when this is done," Adora said with a grin.

“And I’m telling you, forcing myself into the water here is more than enough,” Catra responded.

Adora set up with a stretch and pulled out her miniature data pad.

“Wait, why are we awake?” she said as she looked at it.

“What do you mean? It’s morning isn’t it?” Catra said.

“It’s like the middle of the night,” Adora said as she showed Catra the time.

“That’s not the middle of the night. More like really, really early morning,” Catra said.

“And if you woke up at this time back home would you be up?” Adora said as she rummaged around for some food.

“Well, no, but I’m awake, I’m not tired, and it’s not like time has any meaning down here,” Catra said.

“Fair,” Adora said as she tossed Catra a small bag of food. “Once we’re done eating, let’s top off any water bottles we have with us and stage some here along with some food. Then we take the gear in and set up for the next drop.”

“You still determined to be the first one down?” Catra said as she chewed on a bar of food.

“Yep,” Adora said. “You going to argue about it?”

Catra sighed as she shook her head. “No. You didn’t when I did that dive so I can’t really fight you on this. But you’re going to set it up and then move back so I can come up and check the anchor and everything.”

Adora nodded as she said, “Fair. I’m just worried about getting tied into the rope. There’s not a lot of room on the lip of the pit.”

“And it’ll make checking you out before you go over almost impossible,” Catra said. They both sat in silence as they realized what they were considering before Adora spoke up.

“We just have to be twice as careful then,” Adora replied.

Catra laughed as she said, “Adora, if we were going to be careful, we wouldn’t even be sitting here.”

Adora gave her a playful shove as she said, “You know what I mean.”

Catra nodded as she got serious. “Yeah, I do.”

After breakfast, they got everything they needed together and moved into the tunnel. They both silently were grateful that they didn’t have as much equipment but it also reminded them that they were on the last day pushing forward as they didn’t have much in the way of supplies to go further and still be able to come back out. At the lip of the pit, Adora got the rope anchored off a little back into the tunnel and moved forward so Catra could inspect it. After Catra did, Adora began to carefully hook herself in, laying down in the tunnel as she did so. She held the ascender Bow had made in her hand and sighed a little as she had the brief thought that she hoped it was as solid as Bow thought.

“OK, I’ll shout when I’m at the ledge,” Adora said. “I’ll signal as well with a light.”

“If the ledge exists,” Catra said.

Adora pointed at the coiled rope at her feet as she said, “I’ve got several knots tied in the last twenty feet and the rope is 250 feet. If I hit the end, I’ll hook the ascender up, come off the descent gear, and come back.”

“And you’re sure you can do that?” Catra said.

Adora wasn’t. She hadn’t done anything like it since she’d been in the Horde but she just nodded.

“Your silence and your face says everything I need to know,” Catra said with a sigh. “Kiss me before you go over.”

“You’re making a big deal out of nothing,” Adora said with a smile as she stretched forward to meet Catra’s kiss.

“I love you,” Catra said. “Make sure you come back so I can say it again.”

“I love you too,” Adora said as she scooted back and kicked the rope she was attached to over the edge. “See you soon.”

As she got close to the edge, she pushed the second bag full of rope attached to her harness in the back over the edge, and then went over herself. Catra carefully crawled to the edge and looked over but couldn’t really see anything aside from the faint light of Adora’s headlamp for a short time.

As Adora descended, she soon realized she was going to go past another waterfall. It was coming out of the rock face about fifty feet down from where she was and she figured it was the same stream that they’d followed to the multiple tunnels. She hung for

a moment and watched it fall when she was just above it before continuing her descent, misted a bit by falling spray. She looked up and could see the glow of Catra's headlamp far above her as she went. It took so long to descend she began to think she'd hit her stopper knots and began to get nervous that she'd have to change to ascent gear hanging over a deep pit when her headlamp began to pick out what looked like a ledge full of crumbled rock. As she sat down on it, she could tell the waterfall was hitting part of the ledge close to her, the rocks were soaked with the spray and the whole thing was titled a little. She looked around and found a few spots she could anchor in and then walked to the edge to look down some more.

"Should have brought radios with us," Adora mumbled as she pulled the rope out of the bag she'd brought down with her and began to tie it off to an anchor point. Then she carefully moved from one rope to the other, not trusting the slight slope of the wet ledge. When she was tied into the new rope, she shouted back up the pit and used one of her flashlights to signal with. It wasn't too long after she saw Catra coming down and was soon standing beside her.

"Are we going to hit a waterfall on *every one of these?"* Catra said.

"Maybe," Adora said. "Something has to form these pits."

"It can form it somewhere else," Catra said, shaking water drops off of herself. "Why are you already tied off?"

“I don’t trust this slope. There’s still several hundred feet beneath us,” Adora said.

“I don’t blame you,” Catra said as she tested the footing. “Alright, you’re already ready. Let me check you real quick and then over you go.”

“You make it sound so relaxed,” Adora said with a laugh.

“At this point it’s be relaxed or just start screaming in horror at the chances we’re taking,” Catra said. “One is productive; one isn’t. I’ll do the productive one.”

Adora nodded and after a quick check, she slid back over the edge, and after a little ways was promptly soaked from the waterfall breaking on the rocks above. When she got to the bottom, she found a large pool of water going from wall to wall.

“Because of course it is,” Adora said with a shake of her head before she signaled for Catra. It took longer for Catra to come down this time but finally she was standing knee deep in the pool next to Adora.

“Really!? A giant pool of water?” Catra said.

“You know, I don’t hate water like you do but I’m certainly starting to,” Adora said.

“You could never hate water like I do,” Catra said. “But I’ll bet you’re definitely starting to understand it better.”

“I think we’re going to have to swim,” Adora said as she used a flashlight to sweep the other side of the pit and showed where the pool narrowed back out into a stream. They could both see what looked like a shore and they both gave a long suffering sigh as they waded into the chill water and felt the bottom drop out from them as they waded forward. The current pulled them along easily and they soon were pulling themselves back up the other side and onto the shore. Another large tunnel sat at the top of the slope on their left as the water itself went into a low ceiling tunnel to their right.

Catra walked up the slope to the large tunnel, water dripping off the edges of her ears as she tried her best to ignore it, when she saw something that drove the thought of the water out of her mind. A large glyph, about three feet tall and almost as wide, was painted on the wall at the entrance to the tunnel. Adora, walking up beside her, saw it as well.

“You know, just when I think there’s no way someone has gone before us, we see something like that,” Adora said.

“I’m going to be really upset if I find a staircase up that pit,” Catra said with a laugh, remembering the wire railing.

"I'd almost rather take the rope," Adora said as she adjusted her pack, thinking of what it would be like to climb stairs over that pit. She took a picture of the glyph with Catra in the shot. "I'm guessing the way is to follow this tunnel."

"Unless that's a big 'Do not enter' sign," Catra said.

"This whole cave is a big do not enter sign," Adora said with a mirthless laugh as she walked down the tunnel. Catra followed along, both of them taking simple pleasure in not having to stoop down or crawl as they went along. The tunnel wound up and down and back and forth for some distance before they began to come out into a huge open cavern.

In the light of their headlamps they could see hanging stalactites, several having reached the ground and formed columns, and several big flowstone formations near them. The ground was covered in broken stones as they began to walk along the wall and they could always hear the constant drip of water in the darkness.

Not too far from the entrance, Catra stopped suddenly. She stared at what could only be called a mural. The forms in it were multi-colored and complex, showing cat people running through an open desert landscape. It was very obviously a playful scene as Catra spotted what looked like several colorful balls being thrown between people. She started to reach out and touch the mural for a second before she brought her hand back and crossed her arms in front of herself in a tight hug.

“Why is that here?” Adora said softly.

“I don’t know,” Catra said and looked around. “Adora… why is this spot covered in sand?”

Adora looked around and then said, “Catra, it’s surrounded by stones. They’ve been laid down.”

Catra walked over and noticed that the stones were carefully placed in a curve surrounding the sandy spot. She crouched down and touched the stones and as she looked up, her headlamp illuminated an arch behind a flowstone formation nearby.

“Adora, there’s an arch over here,” Catra said.

“To another room?”

“I guess but it’s not natural, it looks cut into the rock,” Catra responded.

The two went over and looked in and saw a small room with another arch cut into the back wall. A wall inside was also colorfully painted, this one showing what looked like an oasis scene in a desert. Several tents sat around a pool of water in the image. Catra carefully stepped inside and looked into the room beyond to see several nooks cut into the wall. A small cup sat

inside one and Catra realized this was a bedroom. She turned around to see Adora standing behind her.

"This is it. This is Half Moon," Catra said, her voice low as she wiped at her eyes.

Chapter End Notes

Half Moon is legend no longer.

Interment

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora seem to have found Half Moon but where is everyone?

Chapter Notes

> OK, I've updated the tags on this to indicate that there is a discussion of death in this chapter. It's not graphic but it is there.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra and Adora left the small home and began to find others carved into the rock wall. They saw evidence of gathering areas out in the cave in front of the wall the homes were carved into and further along they saw handholds carved into the rock and going up the wall to other smaller nooks. Catra climbed several and found similar structures, a few small rooms carved into the rock, and obviously used as homes. Everywhere they found artwork painted on the walls. Some of the ceilings were painted to look like the sky at various times of the day and night. Little things like the cup had been left strewn about. After some searching, Adora set up several of their flashlights to try and light the area and get a sense of how big it was while Catra sat on a rock bench among other rock benches in a small circle. She held the small cup they'd found and turned it in her hand, looking at the patterns fired into the beautiful porcelain.

"Where are they?" Catra said.

"I don't know," Adora replied as she sat down next to her.

“I mean, the biggest group of cat people I’ve ever seen was out in the Waste and that was just a small town. Other than that, it’s just scattered groups across Etheria that I’ve noticed. I thought maybe they’d be here but…,” she trailed off as she listened to the silence broken only by an occasional drip of water.

“Did you think you were coming down to save them?” Adora said.

Catra gave a sad smile as she shook her head and said, “Not save them but maybe get them in contact with the world again. Let them know they could come back out and join us.”

Adora thought she could see what Catra was thinking. That she could pay forward what someone had done for her by saving someone and letting them finally live a life but she didn’t say anything as she put an arm around Catra.

“It’s like you said though,” Catra said. “I’m kind of glad they weren’t here. Centuries living down here? That sounds horrifying the more I think about it.”

“It looks like they lived as best they could. The paintings, the stuff they left is nice, obviously they had places they could gather and be together,” Adora said. “It couldn’t have been easy but there’s no reason to think it was joyless.”

Catra nodded as she sat the cup down on the bench next to her and said, "Let's see what else we can find and… can we camp here tonight?"

"You sure?" Adora said.

Catra nodded as she said, "Yeah, I'm sure."

"I've got no problem then," Adora said.

They got up and began to look some more and not long after found a short, wide staircase descending down to an archway. The arch was ornately carved, as were the two stone doors set in it. It was obvious this had been a place of importance for the people who'd lived in the cave so Catra found it odd that both doors were partially open. She began to go down the staircase and then stopped, frozen in place. Adora, taking a few pictures, saw her suddenly stop.

"What's wrong?"

"There's a body," Catra said. "It's just inside the doors."

Adora walked down to stand beside her and saw the body, dressed in long, flowing clothes and laying against the door on the inside.

“What do we do?” Adora whispered.

Catra, shaking, didn’t say anything but went forward and crouched down next to the body and then looked up. She turned back to Adora, her face haunted as she said, “It’s a tomb. There’s niches all along the wall and they have people in them. There’s some bodies sitting on the floor too.”

Adora came down to her and looked inside. The room went back for some distance and as Catra said, there were niches carved into the rock and in each one someone had been carefully placed, wrapped in cloth. Beside the head of each niche was a paw print in paint and some writing she didn’t recognize. Some of the niches had more than one body, especially near the back, some obviously children with an adult. A few dozen bodies sat around the chamber on the ground, mostly clumped together in groups of two or three. Adora began walking back along the rows and went some distance back. At the back, she saw some unused niches. When she came back, Catra was still knelt down.

“I think it’s a couple hundred at least,” Adora said.

“I guess this is where Half Moon went,” Catra said as she looked up.

“I don’t know,” Adora said, looking at a few of the bodies near the front. “These in the niches up here look older than some in the back. Do you think maybe they got attacked?”

“No. I’ve been looking at this one,” Catra said, looking down at the body against the door. “They’ve got jewelry on. You’d think if it was an attack, it would have been taken off of them. Their clothes aren’t ripped or anything either. I think this one was trying to close the doors. Maybe there was an illness and they were trying to seal themselves in for safety.”

“But why? It wouldn’t be very safe for them in here,” Adora said.

“Not for themselves,” Catra said. “I think that’s why these aren’t interred. They were already sick and were trying to isolate themselves from whoever was left outside. Maybe whoever was left fled finally.”

They both sat there in silence with their thoughts. Catra kept thinking she should feel spooked but she couldn’t feel that. She felt an ache in her chest that threatened to spill over into tears for whatever had happened to these people and how they’d more than likely lay out on the ground for centuries and she made up her mind of what to do.

“Adora, we’re burying them,” she said, not looking up.

“There’s empty niches at the back,” Adora replied immediately.

They carefully began to place the bodies into the niches, putting the ones who'd died together into a niche together. They both noticed that most of the bodies had little things left with them and they went back out to the little homes they'd gone in and took out the things they'd found and placed something with each person they interred. Finally, they took the last one, the one they'd found trying to close the door, and placed them in a niche. Catra placed the cup she'd found into their hand and Adora stood there with an arm around her.

"Should we say something?" she said.

Catra thought for a moment and said, "Rest now. I'll make sure to close the doors for you."

Adora nodded and the two left, pushing the doors closed to the tomb. Adora got out a piece of waterproof paper from a small journal she had and wrote on it before wedging it into the crack of the door.

"What's that?" Catra said, sitting on the steps watching her.

"I put down that this is a tomb," Adora said as she sat down next to her. "I'm sure others will come after us and they should know before they try and open it."

"About that… when we get back out, I, uh, I want someone to come in and research this place. I want them to find out as much

as they can," Catra said. She turned her attention from Adora and looked at the tomb. "But not that. Never that."

"I can seal it if you want," Adora said as the Sword of Protection flashed into her hand.

Catra thought long and hard about that before she finally said, "No. If somehow we ever find people who know about this, whose ancestors are in there, I want them to be able to see if they want. No one else though. We let whoever else comes down know what's there and that it is not for research and not to be disturbed. Let them rest."

They camped in the little circle of benches that night. Neither one spoke much and while they both thought they wouldn't be able to sleep, as soon as they turned off the lights and Adora had set out a chem-light, they drifted off without noticing it. When they woke up, they got ready to leave and Catra went to the tomb one more time by herself.

She couldn't quite articulate why but she carefully ground up a small bit of red stone she'd found with one of the carabineers from her climbing gear. Then she mixed in a little bit of grease they had in the first aid kit with it and coated the palm of her hand. She carefully placed her hand over where the doors met and left her paw print there. She nodded once, stood a moment longer in silence, and then walked back to Adora to begin the long trek back to the surface.

A little less than two days later, they emerged into the daylight. They'd been smelling the surface since they'd left the Paw Print room, faintly at first as if it was just a dream and then stronger as they went up The Slide and finally bursting into their noses as they made their way up the Entry Room and out the entrance tunnel and into what seemed like riotous color and light. The greens and blues of the forest seemed to assault their eyes as they both squeezed their eyes almost closed and sat down on the rocks at the entrance, their gear piled up around them. They'd left some of it back at the top of Paw Print Pit and would have to go back in for it later but for now, they just sat and enjoyed the warmth and light as they switched off their headlamps and Adora sent out a message that they'd got out safely.

"You think any of them survived?" Catra said after a long moment of quiet.

"Probably," Adora said.

Catra nodded as she said, "That's what I think too but maybe it's just wishful thinking."

"Naw," Adora said, bumping her a little. "If they were anything like you, there's no way they could be wiped out."

Catra smiled at her as she said, "That's true. Even if they didn't, well, it took a war, fleeing across Etheria, hiding in a cave, and probably pestilence to get them. I'd say that's a fair fight."

"And they cared for each other," Adora said, thinking of the paintings, the gathering places, and the carefully interred bodies. "You come from good people."

Catra sighed a little as she nodded. "I do."

Epilogue

It was months before someone else went down into what became known as Half Moon cave. Catra and Adora kept the place a secret while they worked with George and Lance to find a group of people they trusted enough to tell about what they'd found. They'd assembled the group and got a promise from them that they would not enter the tomb at all.

Catra and Adora went with the first team to the cave but didn't go back in with them. They stayed on top as a support team with Kyle, Rogelio, and Lonnie. It was lucky they did because the research team ended up needing rescue when a massive thunderstorm rolled over the area. When the team went past their return time, Adora and Catra had gone in after them with Kyle and Lonnie and found the bottom of Paw Print Pit a full pool and the whole tunnel flooded out. Glimmer and Bow had both been off planet or they would have tried to bring her in to try and teleport into the room and get them out.

In the end, they'd been in contact with Entrapta and Hordak in Dryl discussing underwater gear to dive to the team and Mermista had been on her way when the water had started to recede. Kyle and Lonnie had gone down the tunnel past Catra Falls, the tunnel

still so full they floated most of the way with their heads crammed against the ceiling, and found the team in the Palace of Pearls, named after the cave pearls in the room Adora had called Room Two. Kyle dove down first, having to go further and deeper than Catra and Adora had the first time through and had broken the surface gasping for air. Several of the research team members actually screamed as he came splashing up out of the water. He had turned to them with a smile and told them he was there to rescue them.

When everyone got out, Rogelio had declared them all out of their minds and hugged Lonnie and Kyle tight. The research team was soaked, exhausted, and half starved. They told the story of becoming trapped when the stream had suddenly risen too high and fast to get out and then the long monotonous wait while they held out hope for rescue or dropping water. It didn't stop them though. After they'd rested, they had gone right back in a few days later when the water had returned to normal and found Half Moon.

Back at their home a few months after that, Catra went over the documentation the research team had sent her. True to their word, they'd left the tomb alone and had even erected a large sign in front of it explaining what it was and that it was not to be disturbed as well as hammering wedges into the bottom to make it difficult to open casually. They'd found a room full of old documents in a language no one understood and found a few other outlying areas that had housed people in the enormous cavern room that Half Moon sat in. They'd also managed to answer a question that Catra had wondered about for some time and she showed Adora as she walked into her studio late one afternoon.

“Remember we were wondering how in the world they got into the bottom of that cave through all that mess we went through?” Catra said, a large map unrolled on her drawing table.

“Yeah, I remember,” Adora said as she looked at the map. Catra tapped at a few spots coming off the Half Moon cavern.

“There’s hidden exits,” Catra said. “The team said it’s still rough going in and out but still easier than multiple rapells, tight squeezes, and having to wade through a river. They said the entrances are deep in the woods and they were all backfilled with rock and dirt. They dug out a narrow tunnel for them to go in and out in one. Oh, and they found a few places in the woods near it where people had lived once and probably raised crops. The structures were completely crumbled but they had murals like the ones in the caves so it looks like at least some of the Half Moon people did get out. Then there’s this.”

Catra held up a piece of paper with a composite image on it made from multiple pictures taken at different locations with large lights. It showed the side of the cavern where the people of Half Moon had lived. It was impossible to see in the image on the paper what they represented but they could see the paintings all over the walls and the nooks that had been the homes.

“I’ve seen the digital version of this and you can zoom in close and see incredible detail. It’s stunning,” Catra said. “Just from looking at the amount of housing, I think there were a lot more people than what we saw in that tomb.”

“What do you think happened to them?” Adora said.

Catra shrugged. “I don’t know. Based on the paintings, I’d say they were from a desert. Maybe the Waste or something like it. After whatever happened, maybe they went back there. Maybe they just dispersed out into the world, lost their history, and those little groups of cat people here and there are what’s left.” She tucked the image back into the folder it came in and sighed. “I think that’s the best answer I’m ever going to get but that’s alright. I can live with that. The research team wants to go back down with some different people as well. I’ll let them fret over it.”

Adora looked over at a large canvas set up in Catra’s studio. It was in the process of getting painted and Adora saw flowing forms like ones she’d last seen in pitch darkness at the bottom of a cave and saw two that looked like her and Catra running with them in play. She placed a hand on Catra’s shoulder as she said, “That sounds like a plan. Come on. I’m starting dinner. Come give me a hand.”

“Can do,” Catra said as she stood up and gave Adora a kiss before they walked down the hall.

Chapter End Notes

> OK, so this started out as a short fic that was supposed to be more on the caving side, and there is plenty of that in there, but then it kept growing and I started to think about what they would find in Half Moon. I always knew that Half Moon would be at the end of the journey and that it would be empty, that there wouldn’t be anyone there, but it was only as I got towards the end that I realized, there’s a tomb. If you’re wondering what happened, I’ll say that I don’t have a

firm idea myself and this isn't anything set in stone and I may change it if I ever use it again but the timeline goes like this.

The people of Half Moon retreat after being attacked in their desert homeland near where the Spirit Ember is located (the Spirit Ember is in the She-Ra graphic novel The Legend of the Fire Princess, the rest is me). They get down to Plumeria, maybe run afoul of some of the people living there and there's some back and forth fighting that drives some people out of the towns near to the cave. I'd say this is also when Plumerians start to become more nomadic. A few of them go into the most obvious location for the cave, the place Catra and Adora go in, explore it, find the large cavern and find the other exits. They move everyone down and make a place to live while a few people stay on the surface and farm. I figure at least a generation does this, long enough for Half Moon to start becoming a bit of a legend, when disease starts running through the population. Some die, some seal up the exits and flee, and the population is dispersed at this point. Catra was on the right track when she says they lost their history and Half Moon becomes a myth. Cue several centuries later and Catra and Adora go caving.

I'd say the descendants of Half Moon are spread out across Etheria (and yes, Catra is one of them) with the biggest group out in the Waste in a little community. Maybe they have a few oral stories that they descended from Half Moon and they were a great society once but it's just something to tell the kids around the dinner table, part of the Half Moon myth. They have more important things to worry about like getting on with day-to-day life and living their lives. I know a few of you had hopes of them actually finding Half Moon still populated and I'm sorry it wasn't.

Finally, I figure I'll put in a few things I learned (or re-learned) while writing this. Flowstone, a type of cave formation, forms at the rate of 0.14 cm/yr. There is a cave in Italy that has footprints that have been preserved for 14,000 years. Caves, especially the big ones, breath. The air pressure

inside is different from that outside and, depending on the pressure difference, the air will come in and out of the cave like a breath. Big cave systems have been found because of breezes coming out of areas that shouldn't have breezes coming out of them. Lechuguilla Cave in New Mexico is an example of this. I also cheated a little and used the Etherian tech to make cave mapping easier. Here on our planet, cave cartography is difficult but rewarding and you can read that link if you want to know more. And finally, because I had to have a cave painting moment from both the murals and Catra leaving her print behind, there are cave paintings found in Leang Bulu' Sipong 4 cave in Sulawesi, Indonesia that are up to 43,000 years old.

I hope you all have had a good time reading this and I thank you for your readership!

Cave Feature Names

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The Slide

-

Paw Print Room

-

Paw Print Pit

-

Catra Falls

-

Palace of Pearls

-

Half Moon Cavern

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!